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<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 1 / 113>

[image]

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BRUNIANA & CAMPANELLIANA

Ricerche filosofiche e materiali storico-testuali

supplementi, xxxiv · studi, 13

<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 3 / 113>

LA SCELTA DI LORENZO

LA PRIMAVERA DI BOTTICELLI

TRA POESIA E FILOSOFIA

CHRISTOPHE PONCET
testo francese con traduzione italiana
di germana ernst
PISA · ROMA
FABRIZIO SERRA EDITORE
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<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 5 / 113>
À mes parents,
Françoise et Jean-André
*
Socrate. Eh bien, dès à présent, Protarque, le premier venu pourrait convenablement nous servir de juge pour décider dans la compétition engagée entre

le plaisir et la sagesse.
Platon, Philèbe, 65ab
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 6 / 113>
Ringrazio le persone che mi hanno sostenuto nell'elaborazione di questo libro e hanno contribuito alla sua realizzazione. In particolare, esprimo la mia gratitudine a Valery Rees, Hiro Hirai, Philippe Truffault, Élisabeth Joliet,
Élie Huvelin, Françoise e Jean-André Poncet, Marie-Noëlle Jean, Paul Jean Zouaoui, Paolo Vian, Stéphane Roger, Jean-Paul Bessières-Orsoni, Rita Gianfelice, Sergio Poletti, Fabrizio Serra, Eugenio Canone e Germana Ernst.
C. P.
Crediti fotografici:
Per concessione della Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, ogni diritto riservato: pp. 16, 18, 20, 24a; Agence Photographique de la Réunion des Musées Nationaux: pp. 8, 12, 24a, 25b, 26, 27a, 37, 38a, 39, 40, 41, 42, 43, 44, 45, 49, 51, 53, 54 , 55, 59, 60, 61, 63a, 64, 65, 67, 68, 69, 71,
72, 73, 75, 76, 78, 80, 81, 82, 83, 84,

86, 87, 88, 89, 90, 91, 92, 93, 94, 95,
96, 97, 99, 100, 101, 103, 104, 106;
Beinecke Rare Book and
Manuscript Library, Yale University: p.
12b; Pierpont Morgan Library, New York:
p. 12a; Villa Stendhal: pp. 9, 10, 11,
13, 15, 20, 21, 22b, 24b,
25a, 27b, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 33, 35,
36, 38b, 63, 78, 79, 85, 105.
Con il sostegno dell’Agence
Photographique de la Réunion des Musées
Nationaux.
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 7 / 113>
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<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 7 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 8 / 113>
ce jour, le Printemps de Botticelli est
demeuré
une énigme. Il faut pourtant rendre
hommage aux
nombreux chercheurs qui ont tenté d’en
percer le secret.
Leurs travaux ont permis de retrouver
presque toutes les
sources de l’œuvre.1 Grâce à eux, nous
en identifions

chaque élément, depuis les neuf
personnages principaux jusqu’à la plus
petite marguerite. De droite à
gauche, nous reconnaissons ainsi Zéphyr
pourchassant
Chloris, nymphe de la terre, puis Flore,
la déesse du
printemps, en train de disperser les
fleurs qu’elle porte
dans un pli de sa robe; au centre Vénus
survolée par
l’Amour, lequel pointe sa flèche sur le
groupe des Trois
Grâces; enfin Mercure élevant son
caducée. Mais à cette
procession mythologique personne n’avait
jamais su apporter une explication
convaincante.2 C’est qu’un autre
personnage, resté en dehors de la
composition dont il
constituait la clef, n’avait pas été
pris en considération:
l’observateur du tableau.
ino ad oggi, la Primavera di Botticelli
è rimasta
un enigma. Si deve tuttavia rendere
omaggio ai

numerosi studiosi che hanno tentato di svelarne il segreto. I loro lavori hanno consentito di rintracciare pressoché tutte le fonti dell’opera.1 Grazie ad essi, siamo in grado di identificare ogni elemento a partire dai nove personaggi principali fino alla più piccola margherita. Da destra a sinistra, riconosciamo così Zefiro che dà la caccia a Cloris, ninfa della terra, quindi Flora, dea della primavera che sta distribuendo i fiori che si trovano in una piega della sua veste. Al centro Venere, sopra la quale si vede Amore che punta la sua freccia sul gruppo delle Tre Grazie. In fine Mercurio che innalza il suo caduceo. Ma di questa sfilata mitologica, nessuno aveva mai dato una spiegazione convincen te.2 Infatti, non era stato preso in considerazione un altro

personaggio, rimasto fuori dalla composizione di
cui forniva la chiave: l’osservatore del quadro.
1 Tra i numerosi lavori dedicati alla Primavera, alcuni saggi sono
di particolare rilievo: Warburg, Botticelli; Wind, Pagan Mysteries; Dempsey, The Portrayal of Love.
2 Le più recenti pubblicazioni si accordano su questo punto:
Cecchi, Botticelli, pp. 152, 161; Marmor, From Purgatory to the Primavera, p. 199; Acidini Luchinat, Botticelli: Les Allégories, p. 9; Villa, Mercurio retrogrado, pp. 6-7.
1 Parmi les nombreux travaux consacrés au Printemps, quelques essais ont été particulièrement remarqués: Warburg, La naissance de
Vénus; Wind, Pagan Mysteries; Dempsey, The Portrayal of Love.
2 Les plus récentes publications s’accordent sur ce point: Cecchi, Botticelli, pp. 152, 161; Marmor, From Purgatory to the Primavera,
p. 199; Acidini Luchinat, Botticelli:

Les Allégories, p. 9; Villa,
Mercurio retrogrado, pp. 6-7.
F À
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 9 / 113>
Per capire il quadro, bisogna cominciare
dal chiarire un’altra immagine, anche
essa fiorentina e
concepita nel medesimo periodo: la carta
dell’Innamorato dei tarocchi di
Marsiglia.1 Al centro, si
vede un uomo in piedi di fronte
all’osservatore.
Egli indossa la veste corta dei giovani
alla moda
nel Quattrocento. La sua testa è volta
verso una
donna alla sua destra. Essi si scambiano
uno sguardo intenso, gli occhi negli
occhi. La donna ha la
mano sinistra posata sulla spalla di lui
e gli accarezza la coscia con la destra.
Dall’altro lato, una giovane donna che
indossa una lunga, semplice veste
tocca il petto dell’uomo proprio
all’altezza del
cuore. Sembra triste, con lo sguardo
volto verso il

basso. L’uomo la respinge con il dorso della mano.
Amore, che sta per lanciare la sua freccia, aleggia
sulla scena.
Pour comprendre le tableau, il nous faut commencer par
élucider une autre image, elle aussi florentine, et conçue
à la même époque: la carte de l’Amoureux du tarot de
Marseille.1 Au milieu, un homme se tient debout, face à
l’observateur. Il porte le vêtement court des jeunes gens
à la mode au Quattrocento. Sa tête est tournée vers
une femme à sa droite. Ils échangent un regard intense,
les yeux dans les yeux. Elle a la main gauche posée sur
son épaule et lui flatte la cuisse avec la droite. De l’autre
côté, une jeune femme vêtue d’un simple manteau
touche le torse de l’homme, juste au niveau du cœur. Elle

paraît triste, avec son regard tombant.
Il la repousse du
revers de la main. L’Amour, sur le point
de décocher sa
flèche, survole la scène.
10 christophe poncet
1 Sulle origini fiorentine dei tarocchi
di Marsiglia, vedi Poncet,
Un gioco.
1 Sur les origines florentines du tarot
de Marseille, voir Poncet, Un
gioco.
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 10 / 113>
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 11
L’Innamorato. L’Amoureux, 1760
(Paris, Bibliothèque Nationale de
France).
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 10 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 11 / 113>
Possiamo leggere l’immagine come si
percorre la
striscia di un fumetto. Il giovane uomo
e la donna
alla sua sinistra costituiscono una
coppia. Lei sta

rispettosamente a fianco del suo sposo, leggermente arretrata. Ha ancora sulla testa la ghirlanda di fiori. Nell'Italia del Rinascimento, secondo la tradizione, la giovane sposa riceveva quest'ornamento alla fine della cerimonia nuziale.1 Il suo gesto in direzione del cuore dell'uomo esprime una tenera intimità. Il movimento del braccio con il quale lui la respinge senza neppure guardarla testimonia anch'esso una certa familiarità.

On peut lire l'image comme on parcourt une bande dessinée. Le jeune homme et la femme à sa gauche forment un couple. Elle se tient respectueusement au côté de son époux, légèrement en retrait. Elle porte encore la guirlande de fleurs sur la tête. Dans l'Italie de la Renaissance, la tradition voulait que la jeune épousée reçoive cet ornement à la fin de la cérémonie nuptiale.1 Le geste

qu’elle fait en direction du cœur de
l’homme exprime
une tendre intimité. Le mouvement de
bras par lequel il
la rejette, sans même la regarder,
témoigne également
d’une certaine familiarité.

1 A proposito di questa tradizione, vedi
Fournel, Furlan,
Famille et mariage, p. 1753; Herald,
Renaissance Dress, p. 244.
1 À propos de cette tradition, voir
Fournel, Furlan, Famille et
mariage, p. 1753; Herald, Renaissance
Dress, p. 244.
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 11 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 12 / 113>
Ces échanges entre les jeunes gens sont
très probablement causés par l’irruption
de l’autre femme. Son assurance, son
port altier, semblent indiquer qu’elle
est plus
expérimentée qu’eux. L’habillement
sophistiqué dont
elle se pare est celui d’une riche

aristocrate, ou bien
d’une prostituée. C’est cette seconde
hypothèse que nous
retiendrons, en considération de la
façon qu’elle a de
porter les mains sur le jeune homme.
Celui-ci, prudent,
refuse d’ouvrir son bras, et garde le
coude fermé en position défensive. Qu’a-
t-il donc à craindre?
L’image ne donne-t-elle pas la réponse,
comme dans
une bulle de bande dessinée? L’Amour
serait ainsi une
représentation du désir de l’homme
suscité en lui par la
vision de la courtisane. Et la flèche
que l’archer pointe
en direction du couple, précisément
entre l’homme et la
femme, figurerait la menace que ce désir
fait peser sur
les liens du mariage. S’il cède aux
avances de la prostituée, l’homme risque
de briser la relation qui l’unit à sa
légitime épouse. Elle-même a pris la
mesure du danger

et tente, par un geste en direction de
son cœur, de le retenir à elle. Cette
lecture peut sembler imaginative.
L’étude iconographique de la carte
montre pourtant
qu’elle est très proche de la
signification voulue à l’origine.
Questi scambi fra i due giovani sono
causati molto
probabilmente dall’irruzione dell’altra
donna, la
cui sicurezza, il cui portamento altero
sembrano
indicare che lei ha più esperienza degli
altre due.
L’abbigliamento sofisticato che ostenta
è quello di
una ricca aristocratica, o anche di una
cortigiana.
Propenderei per questa seconda ipotesi,
in considerazione del modo in cui le sue
mani si posano
sul giovane uomo: il quale,
prudentemente, rifiuta
di aprire il suo braccio e mantiene il
gomito chiuso
in posizione difensiva. Ma che cosa ha

da temere?
L’immagine non dà essa stessa la
risposta? Amore sarebbe così una
raffigurazione del desiderio
dell’uomo suscitato in lui dalla vista
della cortigiana, e la freccia che
l’arciere punta in direzione della
coppia, precisamente fra l’uomo e la
donna, rappresenterebbe la minaccia per
i vincoli coniugali
che trae origine da questo desiderio. Se
l’uomo cede alle avances della
cortigiana, rischia di porre fine
alla relazione che lo unisce alla
legittima sposa. La
quale si è resa conto del pericolo e,
con un gesto
diretto al cuore di lui, cerca di
trattenerlo. Una lettura che può
sembrare immaginosa; ma lo studio
iconografico della carta mostra che essa
è molto
prossima al significato originario.
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 13
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 12 / 113>
[image]

L’immagine eredita il suo schema generale dai tarocchi miniati creati a Milano all’inizio del xv secolo. Il modello canonico rappresenta una coppia che si stringe la mano sotto un Amore dagli occhi
bendati. La stretta di mano non deve essere interpretata come un semplice saluto: si tratta della
dextrarum junctio, il rito, praticato fino dall’antichità romana, che suggellava l’unione coniugale.
L’image hérite son schéma général des tarots enluminés
créés à Milan au début du quinzième siècle. Le modèle
canonique représente un couple qui se serre la main audessous d’un Amour aux yeux bandés. La poignée de
mains ne doit pas être interprétée comme un simple salut: c’est la dextrarum junctio, le rite, pratiqué depuis l’Antiquité romaine, par lequel était scellée l’union matrimoniale.

Bonifacio Bembo (?), Gli amanti. Les

amoureux, 1450 (?)
(New York, Pierpont Morgan Library).
Bonifacio Bembo (?), Gli amanti. Les
amoureux, 1445 (?)
(New York, Yale University Library).
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 13 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 14 / 113>
De cette composition, la carte de
l’Amoureux garde la
structure triangulaire dominée par un
Amour. L’idée de
mariage est également conservée, mais
plus discrètement, la guirlande de
fleurs jouant un rôle analogue à
la dextrarum junctio.
Di questa composizione, la carta
dell’Innamorato
mantiene la struttura triangolare
dominata da
Amore. È conservata anche l’idea di
matrimonio,
ma in modo più discreto, in quanto la
ghirlanda di
fiori gioca un ruolo analogo alla
dextrarum junctio.
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de

laurent 15
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 14 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 15 / 113>
Ma l’ideatore dei tarocchi di Marsiglia aggiunge
una seconda donna alla scena: e per farlo modifica
la composizione, ispirandosi a un’altra fonte. Si
tratta di una miniatura che raffigura la ‘scelta di
Ercole’, eseguita nel 1463 da Felice Feliciano, un artista e letterato
veronese.1 Le corrispondenze fra
le due immagini sono troppe per essere
semplicemente frutto del caso: 1) stessa struttura con un
uomo affiancato da due donne; 2) stesso orientamento dei corpi nello spazio:
l’uomo di fronte
all’osservatore con la testa girata di tre quarti verso una donna di profilo;
dall’altro lato una seconda
donna con il corpo di fronte e il viso di profilo; 3)
Mais le créateur du Tarot de Marseille

ajoute une
deuxième femme à la scène. Pour ce
faire, il modifie sa
composition en prenant modèle sur une
autre source. Il
s’agit d’une miniature, représentant le
‘Choix d’Hercule’, peinte en 1463 par
Felice Feliciano, un artiste et
homme de lettres originaire de Vérone.1
Les correspondances entre les deux
images sont trop nombreuses pour
être le simple fruit du hasard: 1) même
structure avec un
homme flanqué de deux femmes; 2) même
orientation
des corps dans l’espace: l’homme face à
l’observateur
avec la tête tournée de trois quarts
vers une femme de
profil; derrière l’homme une autre femme
avec le corps
de face et le visage de profil; 3) même
échange de regards;

1 Su Felice Feliciano, vedi Contò,
Quaquarelli, L’antiquario
Felice Feliciano; Mitchell, Felice

Feliciano Antiquarius; Mantovani, La maestà della lettera antica.

1 Sur Felice Feliciano, voir Contò, Quaquarelli, L’antiquario Felice Feliciano; Mitchell, Felice Feliciano Antiquarius; Mantovani, La maestà della lettera antica.

Felice Feliciano, La scelta di Ercole. Le choix d’Hercule, 1463 (Città del Vaticano, Biblioteca Apostolica Vaticana, Reg. Lat. 1388, f. 14r).

<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 15 / 113>

[image]

<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 16 / 113>

4) même coiffure à pointes; 5) même interaction physique entre l’homme et la femme au chapeau: la femme touchant l’homme, l’homme en position défensive; Hercule lui fait barrage avec sa massue plantée dans le sol, le jeune homme oppose plus simplement son coude.

Deux détails laissent penser que la carte est directement adaptée de la miniature. Le sol, dans les deux images, est de couleur jaune et arrive

au même niveau
par rapport aux jambes du personnage
masculin, en
haut du mollet. D’autre part, la main
gauche d’Hercule
fait le même geste que la main droite de
la courtisane
dans la carte. Ces deux mains sont
posées sur la cuisse
droite du jeune homme, à la même
hauteur.
stesso scambio di sguardi; 4) stesso
copricapo a
punte; 5) stessa interazione fisica fra
l’uomo e la
donna con il copricapo: la donna che
tocca l’uomo, l’uomo in posizione
difensiva; Ercole la blocca
con la sua clava piantata al suolo, il
giovane uomo
più semplicemente oppone il suo gomito.
Due particolari fanno pensare che la
carta è
adattata direttamente dalla miniatura.
Il terreno in
entrambe le immagini è di colore giallo
e giunge

al medesimo livello rispetto alle gambe
del personaggio maschile, all’altezza
dei polpacci. In secondo luogo, la mano
sinistra di Ercole fa lo stesso gesto
della mano destra della cortigiana nella
carta.
Entrambe queste mani si appoggiano sulla
coscia
destra dell’uomo appena sotto l’anca.
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 17
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 16 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 17 / 113>
L’immagine di Felice Feliciano illustra
un manoscritto che contiene la storia
della ‘scelta di Ercole’
narrata da Senofonte. Ercole
all’incrocio della via
del vizio con quella della virtù è
avvicinato da due
donne.1 L’una, nobile e decorosa, che si
presenta
come la Virtù, gli offre una vita
difficile ma ricca di
vere soddisfazioni. L’altra, chiamata
Piacere dai

suoi amici e Vizio dagli altri, ben
vestita e truccata,
gli promette una vita facile e
piacevole:
[…] Eracle, al momento
del passaggio dalla fanciullezza alla
giovinezza,
quando i giovani, ormai
padroni di sé, mostrano se
nella vita si indirizzeranno
sulla via della virtù o su
quella del vizio, si recò in
un luogo solitario e seduto
si domandava quale strada
prendere; ed ecco gli apparvero due
donne che venivano verso di lui: erano
alte entrambe, ma l’una di
bell’aspetto e di natura nobile, la
purezza abbelliva il
suo volto, il pudore il suo
sguardo, aveva andatura
composta, e indossava una
veste bianca; l’altra, cresciuta per
essere ben tornita e morbida, aveva il
viso
imbellettato, in modo da
sembrare più bianca e rossa di quello

che era, e un
portamento tale da sembrare più eretta
del naturale, lo sguardo era sfacciato e
la veste lasciava
intrav vedere generosamente le sue belle
forme.
Spesso si guardava con compiacimento, ma
guardava
anche se qualcun altro la osservava, e
più volte si voltava a guardare la sua
ombra. Quando arrivarono più
vicino a Eracle, quella che si è
descritta per prima, procedette alla
solita andatura, ma l'altra, per
precederla,
corse incontro a Eracle e gli disse:
«Vedo che tu, o Eracle, sei in dubbio su
quale indirizzo dare alla tua vita.
Allora, se mi farai tua amica, io ti
porterò per la strada
più dolce e facile, e non ci sarà
piacere che tu non gusterai e passerai
la vita senza fare esperienza del
dolore. Per prima cosa, infatti, non ti
preoccuperai di guerre o di affari, ma
passerai il tempo cercando quale cibo
o bevanda possa trovare che siano

graditi o che cosa
vedendo o ascoltando ti diletti, o che
cosa odorando o
toccando ti dia piacere, o stando con
quali amanti soddisfi di più la tua
passione e come possa dormire nel
modo più dolce e come possa raggiungere
tutte queste cose senza sforzo. E se mai
ti venisse il sospetto di
trovarti in scarsezza dei mezzi da cui
si ottengono queste cose, non avere
paura che io ti conduca a procurartele
con fatica e sofferenza del corpo e
dell’anima; anzi, ti servirai delle cose
che gli altri producono col loro
lavoro, senza privarti di
niente da cui sia possibile
guadagnare qualcosa. Da
ogni parte, infatti, possono trarre
guadagni coloro
a cui offro la mia compagnia». Ed
Eracle, dopo
averla ascoltata, chiese:
«Donna, come ti chiami?»
E quella «Felicità mi chiamano gli
amici, ma quelli
che mi odiano mi chiamano con disprezzo

Vizio». E
intanto l’altra donna, avvicinatasi,
disse: «Anch’io
giungo a te, o Eracle, conoscendo i tuoi
genitori e
avendo osservato il tuo carattere
durante l’educazione, cose dalle quali
spero,
se ti metterai per la mia
strada, potrai realizzare
con abilità opere belle ed
elevate, ed io apparirò
ancor più nobile e magnifica per le
belle imprese
che tu avrai compiuto sotto la mia
guida. Non ti ingannerò con promesse
allettanti, ma ti spiegherò
senza menzogne come gli
dèi hanno ordinato la realtà. Delle cose
buone e belle che ci sono, infatti,
nessuna essi concedono agli uomini senza
fatica e impegno,
ma se vuoi che siano benevoli verso di
te, devi aver cura di loro e, se vuoi
l’affetto degli amici, devi procurare
loro dei benefici e, se vuoi onori da
una città, devi aiutarla, e se vuoi che

la Grecia intera ti ammiri per la tua
virtù, devi cercare di fare qualcosa di
buono per la
Grecia, se vuoi che la terra ti dia in
abbondanza dei
frutti, devi coltivarla, se pensi di
dover diventare ricco
col bestiame, devi curarlo, se miri ad
accrescere il tuo
potere con la guerra e vuoi poter
ottenere la libertà
degli amici e la sottomissione dei
nemici, devi imparare le arti marziali
da coloro che le conoscono ed allenarti
a usarle come bisogna. Se poi anche col
corpo
vuoi essere abile, devi prendere
l’abitudine di sotto18 christophe poncet
1 Sulla ricezione del tema della ‘scelta
di Ercole’ nel Rinascimento, vedi
Panofsky, Ercole al bivio.
Felice Feliciano, Hercules Xenophontius,
1463
(Città del Vaticano, Biblioteca
Apostolica Vaticana,
Reg. Lat. 1388, f. 18r).
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 18 / 113>

mettere il corpo alla mente e devi fare ginnastica con
fatica e sudore». Il Vizio, secondo il racconto di Prodico, replicando disse:
«Vedi, o Eracle, come aspra e lunga è la strada al piacere che quella donna ti mostra? Io
invece ti guiderò alla felicità per una strada facile e breve». E la virtù:
«Sciagurata, e che beni possiedi tu? Quale piacere conosci tu, che non vuoi fare niente per
ottenere queste cose? Tu non aspetti neanche di desiderare le cose piacevoli, ma prima ancora di provarne
la voglia, ti riempi di tutto, mangi prima di provare fame, bevi prima di avere sete e ti procuri dei cuochi per mangiare con piacere, e per bere con piacere acquisti
vini pregiati e d'estate t'affanni a cercare la neve, e per
provare piacere nel sonno ti prepari non solo materassi e coperte morbidi, ma anche sostegni elastici sotto i
letti; perché tu vuoi dormire, non per riposarti dalla

fatica, ma perché non hai niente da
fare. E i piaceri
d’amore tu li susciti forzatamente prima
del bisogno,
escogitando di tutto e usando gli uomini
come donne;
così infatti ammaestri i tuoi amici,
corrompendoli di
notte e facendoli dormire durante il
tempo più prezioso della giornata. Anche
se sei immortale gli dèi ti
hanno respinto e gli uomini onesti ti
disprezzano. La
cosa che è più dolce di tutte a
sentirsi, una lode di sé
stessi, tu non la senti mai, e ciò che è
più bello a vedere
tu non lo vedi mai, perché mai hai visto
qualcosa di
bello che sia opera tua. Chi crederebbe
a quello che dici? Chi ti darebbe aiuto
quando avessi bisogno di qualcosa? O
chi, avendo giudizio, oserebbe far parte
del
tuo gruppo? I giovani sono indeboliti
nei corpi, i vecchi nella mente,
allevati negli agi, senza fatiche

durante la giovinezza, squallidi e con
stento attraversano la
vecchiaia, vergognosi delle azioni
passate, oppressi
dalle presenti, bruciati in gioventù
tutti i piaceri, han
messo da parte per la vecchiaia i
dolori. Io mi accompagno con gli dèi e
con gli uomini onesti: nessuna bella
impresa né divina né umana si fa senza
di me. Sono
la più onorata di tutti presso gli dèi e
presso gli uomini
cui si addice onorarmi; sono
collaboratrice amata degli artigiani,
guardiana fidata della casa per i
proprietari, soccorritrice del lavoro in
tempo di pace, alleata stabile nelle
imprese di guerra, ottima compartecipe
dell’amicizia. I miei amici godono
dolcemente e senza
doversi affaccendare del cibo e del
bere; infatti evitano
queste cose fin quando non ne provano
desiderio. Il
sonno è più dolce per loro che per la
gente oziosa, né

si crucciano dovendo abbandonarlo, né tralasciano per
esso di fare quello che devono. E i giovani si rallegrano
delle lodi dei vecchi, e i più vecchi gioiscono del rispetto dei più giovani;
e con piacere ricordano le imprese
del tempo passato, e si compiacciono di ben agire al
presente, essendo per causa mia cari
agli dèi, amati dagli amici, onorati
dalle patrie. Quando poi viene il
termine stabilito dal destino, non giacciono dimenticati e
senza gloria, ma fioriscono perennemente ricordati
nei canti. Se ti prenderai cura di
affrontare questi sacrifici, tu potrai,
o Eracle, figlio di nobili genitori,
acquistare la più beata felicità».1

1 Senofonte, Memorabili, ii, 21-33, pp. 161-169.

L’image de Felice Feliciano illustre un
manuscrit contenant l’histoire, racontée

par Xénophon, du ‘Choix
d’Hercule’: Hercule, au carrefour entre
la voie du vice et
celle de la vertu, est abordé par deux
femmes.1 L’une, noble et décente, qui se
présente comme la Vertu, lui offre
une vie difficile mais pleine de
récompenses véritables.
L’autre, appelée Volupté par ses amis et
Mollesse par les
autres, bien vêtue, et maquillée, lui
promet une vie facile
et plaisante:
Héraclès venait de sortir de
l’enfance pour entrer dans la
jeunesse; il était à cet âge où
les jeunes gens devenus déjà
maîtres d’eux-mêmes, laissent voir s’ils
entreront dans
la vie par le chemin de la
vertu ou par celui du vice.
Étant sorti de chez lui, il
s’était assis dans un lieu solitaire et
se demandait laquelle
de ces deux routes il allait
prendre, quand il vit venir à
lui deux femmes de haute

taille. L’une avait un aspect
décent et noble, un regard pudique, un
maintien modeste;
elle était vêtue de blanc. L’autre,
qu’un régime particulier
avait rendue potelée et délicate, avait
fardé son visage
pour paraître plus blanche et
plus vermeille qu’elle n’était
réellement; elle se tenait de
manière à exhausser sa taille
naturelle; elle avait les yeux
grands ouverts; elle portait la
toilette la plus propre à laisser
transparaître sa beauté; elle
se regardait souvent et observait si on
la lorgnait, et souvent elle jetait sur
son ombre un regard de côté.
Quand elles se furent rapprochées
d’Héraclès, la première
s’avança sans changer d’allure; mais
l’autre, voulant la prévenir, courut
vers lui et lui dit: «Je vois, Héraclès,
que tu es
embarrassé de savoir par quelle route tu
vas entrer dans la
vie. Prends-moi pour amie, et je te

conduirai par la route la
plus agréable et la plus facile; il n’y
aura pas de plaisirs que
tu ne goûtes, et tu passeras ta vie sans
connaître la peine.
D’abord tu ne t’inquiéteras ni des
guerres ni des affaires. Tu
ne t’occuperas qu’à chercher des mets et
des boissons qui te
plaisent, des objets qui réjouissent tes
yeux et tes oreilles ou
flattent ton odorat ou ton toucher,
quels jeunes garçons tu auras le plus de
plaisir à fréquenter, comment tu
dormiras avec
le plus de mollesse et comment tu
obtiendras toutes ces jouissances avec
le moins de peine. Si jamais tu as
quelque crainte
de manquer de ressources pour te les
procurer, tu n’as pas à
redouter que je te réduise à travailler
et à peiner du corps et
de l’esprit pour te les payer; tu
jouiras du travail des autres,
sans t’abstenir de rien de ce qui pourra
t’apporter quelque

profit; car je donne à ceux qui me
suivent la faculté de prendre
leurs avantages partout.»
Héraclès, ayant entendu ce discours:
«Femme, dit-il, quel
est ton nom?» Elle répondit:
«Mes amis m’appellent la Félicité, et
mes ennemis me
donnent par dénigrement le
nom de Mollesse.» À ce moment, l’autre
femme s’approcha et dit: «Moi aussi, je
suis
venue vers toi, Héraclès. Je
connais tes parents et j’ai
pris note de ton caractère au
cours de ton éducation. Aussi
j’espère, si tu prends la route
qui conduit vers moi, que tu
seras un jour un vaillant
homme qui accomplira de
beaux et nobles travaux, et
que moi-même je serai beaucoup plus
honorée et plus
illustre, grâce à tes bonnes
actions. Je ne préluderai
point en te promettant du
plaisir, car je ne veux pas te

tromper, mais je t’exposerai
en toute vérité les choses telles
qu’elles ont été établies par
les dieux. De ce qui est bon et
beau, les dieux effectivement
ne donnent rien aux hommes
sans exiger d’eux du travail
et de l’application; mais si tu
veux que les dieux te soient
propices, il faut que tu adores
les dieux; si tu veux que tes amis te
chérissent, il faut faire
du bien à tes amis; si tu veux qu’un
pays t’honore, tu dois
être utile à ce pays; si tu prétends que
toute la Grèce admire
ta vertu, tu dois essayer de faire du
bien à toute la Grèce; si
tu veux que la terre te donne des fruits
en abondance, tu dois
cultiver la terre; si tu crois devoir
t’enrichir par des troupeaux, il faut
que tu prennes soin des troupeaux; si tu
aspires à te grandir par la guerre et si
tu veux être à même de
rendre libres tes amis et de soumettre
tes ennemis, tu dois apprendre l’art de

la guerre de ceux qui le connaissent et
t’exercer à le pratiquer; si tu veux
acquérir la force du corps, tu
dois habituer ton corps à se soumettre à
l’intelligence et
l’exercer par les travaux et les
sueurs». Ici la Mollesse reprit
la parole, au dire de Prodicos et dit:
«Comprends-tu, Héraclès, combien pénible
et longue est la route que cette femme

1 Sur la réception de l’histoire du
‘choix d’Hercule’ à la Renaissance,
lire Panofsky, Hercule à la croisée des
chemins.
Felice Feliciano, Hercules Xenophontius,
1463
(Città del Vaticano, Biblioteca
Apostolica Vaticana,
Reg. Lat. 1388, f. 19r).

te trace pour arriver aux plaisirs; moi,
c’est par une route aisée et courte que
je te conduirai au bonheur.»
Alors la Vertu dit: «Misérable, quel
bien possèdes-tu? Quel
agrément connais-tu, toi qui ne veux

rien faire pour le gagner, qui n’attends
même pas le désir du plaisir; qui te
remplis de tout avant de le désirer; qui
manges avant d’avoir
faim, qui bois avant d’avoir soif; qui,
pour manger avec plaisir, cherches des
cuisiniers; qui, pour boire avec plaisir
te procures des vins coûteux et qui, en
été, cours partout chercher
de la neige; qui, pour dormir
agréablement, te procures non
seulement des couvertures moelleuses,
mais encore des sangles sous tes lits;
car ce n’est pas la fatigue, c’est
l’oisiveté qui
te fait désirer le sommeil. En amour, tu
provoques le besoin,
avant de l’éprouver, tu imagines mille
artifices et tu te sers des
hommes comme de femmes; car c’est ainsi
que tu formes tes
amis: la nuit tu les dégrades et tu leur
fais perdre à dormir la
partie la plus utile du jour. Tu es
immortelle et tu as été rejetée par les
dieux, et tu es méprisée par les
honnêtes gens. Ce

qu’il y a au monde de plus agréable à
entendre, ton éloge, tu
ne l’entends jamais, et ce qu’il y a de
plus agréable à voir tu
ne le vois pas; car jamais tu n’as
contemplé une belle action
faite par toi. Qui voudrait ajouter foi
à tes paroles? Qui voudrait te venir en
aide dans le besoin? Quel homme sensé
voudrait se mêler à ton bruyant cortège?
Quand ils sont jeunes,
tes sectateurs ont un corps débile;
quand ils sont devenus
vieux, une âme abêtie. Nourris dans
l’oisiveté, ils sont florissants
d’embonpoint dans leur jeunesse; puis le
corps amaigri, ils passent une
laborieuse vieillesse, rougissant de ce
qu’ils ont fait, accablés de ce qu’ils
ont à faire; ayant couru
de plaisir en plaisir durant leur
jeunesse, ils ont mis en réserve les
peines pour la vieillesse. Moi, au
contraire, je vis
avec les dieux, je vis avec les gens de
bien; aucune belle action
ne se fait sans moi, ni dans le ciel, ni

sur la terre; personne
n’est aussi honorée que moi, ni chez les
dieux, ni chez les
hommes à qui il appartient de m’honorer.
Pour les artisans,
je suis une auxiliaire aimée; pour les
maîtres, une fidèle gardienne de la
maison; pour les serviteurs une
protectrice bienveillante; pour les
travaux de la paix, une bonne
auxiliaire;
dans les fatigues de la guerre, une
alliée solide, et dans l’amitié, une
excellente associée. Mes amis jouissent
du manger et
du boire avec plaisir et sans se donner
de peine; car ils attendent d’en sentir
le désir. Ils ont un sommeil plus
agréable que
les oisifs; ils l’interrompent sans
chagrin, et ne négligent
point pour lui leurs devoirs. Jeunes,
ils ont le plaisir d’être
loués par les vieillards; vieux, ils
sont fiers des respects de la
jeunesse. C’est une joie pour eux de se
rappeler leurs actions

passées et ils n’ont pas moins de
plaisir à faire celles que le
présent exige. Par moi, ils sont amis
des dieux, chéris de leurs
amis, honorés de leur patrie, et, quand
vient le terme fatal,
ils ne gisent point oubliés et sans
honneurs, mais leur souvenir fleurit
d’âge en âge dans les hymnes qui les
célèbrent.
Quant à toi, Héraclès, fils de parents
vertueux, si tu veux déployer tes
efforts comme j’ai dit, tu peux
atteindre à la suprême félicité.»1
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 21
1 Xénophon, Mémorables, ii, 21-33, pp.
359-362.
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 21 / 113>
La descrizione delle due donne di
Senofonte sembra riprodotta fedelmente
nella carta dell’Innamorato. La donna
che si presenta come la Voluttà è
descritta come
cresciuta per essere ben tornita e
morbida, aveva il viso
imbellettato, in modo da sembrare più

bianca e rossa
di quello che era, e un portamento tale
da sembrare più
eretta del naturale, lo sguardo era
sfacciato e la veste lasciava
intravvedere generosamente le sue belle
forme.
Spesso si guardava con compiacimento, ma
guardava
anche se qualcun altro la osservava, e
più volte si voltava a guardare la sua
ombra.
La maggior parte di questi tratti si
ritrova senz'altro nella carta: si noti
in particolare le pieghe del
collo che tradiscono un corpo ben
nutrito. Il copricapo la rende più alta
e il taglio del suo vestito,
stretto alla vita da una cintura,
sottolinea le sue
forme.
La description des deux femmes par
Xénophon semble
fidèlement transposée dans la carte de
l'Amoureux.
Ainsi celle qui se présente comme la
Volupté,

qu’un régime particulier avait rendue potelée et délicate,
avait fardé son visage pour paraître plus blanche et plus vermeille qu’elle n’était réellement; elle se tenait de manière à
exhausser sa taille naturelle; elle avait les yeux grands ouverts; elle portait la toilette la plus propre à laisser transparaître sa beauté; elle se regardait souvent et observait si on la lorgnait, et souvent elle jetait sur son ombre un regard de
côté.
On retrouve sans peine la plupart de ces traits dans la
carte: noter en particulier les plis du cou, qui trahissent
une chair potelée. Son chapeau la grandit et la coupe de
sa robe, ajustée à la taille par une ceinture, souligne ses
formes.

<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 21 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 22 / 113>

De même, le sage portrait de la Vertu semble se refléter
dans l’autre figure féminine de la carte qui
avait un aspect décent et noble, un regard pudique, un maintien modeste.
Les yeux baissés de la jeune épousée, comme la légère inclinaison de sa tête, contrastent en effet avec l’allure altière et le regard effronté de sa rivale. Son sobre habillement, une simple tunique recouverte d’un long et droit
manteau, s’oppose par sa discrétion à l’accoutrement
tapageur de la dame au chapeau.
In modo analogo, il ritratto dignitoso della Virtù
sembra riflettersi nell’altra figura femminile della
carta:
di bell’aspetto e di natura nobile, la purezza abbelliva il
suo volto, il pudore il suo sguardo, aveva andatura
composta.
Gli occhi bassi della giovane sposa, la

lieve inclinazione della sua testa contrastano, infatti, con il portamento altero e lo sguardo sfrontato della rivale. Il suo abbigliamento sobrio, una semplice tunica ricoperta da un mantello lungo e diritto, si contrappone, per la sua discrezione, a quello stravagante e vistoso della donna con il copricapo.

la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de laurent 23

<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 22 / 113>

[image]

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Tuttavia, non è possibile vedere nell'immagine della carta una rappresentazione della 'scelta di Ercole', poiché il giovane uomo ha perso tutti gli attributi tradizionali dell'eroe: la clava, la pelle di leone, la barba, la nudità eroica. Ma chi è il personaggio che ha preso il posto di Ercole fra le due donne?

La risposta a questa domanda si può trovare negli scritti del filosofo

fiorentino Marsilio Ficino
(1433-1499). Amico e consigliere di
Lorenzo de’ Medici (1449-1492), è a lui
che dedica la sua traduzione
del dialogo platonico intitolato Filebo.
Nella lettera
di dedica, Ficino paragona la ‘scelta di
Ercole’ alla
famosa storia del ‘giudizio di Paride’,
secondo la
quale il pastore Paride aveva scelto
Venere a danno
di Giunone e Minerva. Ficino introduce
poi una
terza scena, che egli intitola ‘Il
giudizio di Filebo’.
La letteratura antica non conosce un
simile ‘giu -
Toutefois, il n’est pas possible de voir
dans l’image de la
carte une représentation du ‘Choix
d’Hercule’, car le
jeune homme a perdu tous les attributs
traditionnels du
héros: la massue, la peau de lion, la
barbe, la nudité
héroïque. Qui donc est le personnage qui

a pris la place
d’Hercule entre les deux femmes?
La réponse à cette question se trouve
dans les écrits
du philosophe florentin Marsile Ficin
(1433-1499). Ami
et conseiller de Laurent de Médicis
(1449-1492), il dédie
à ce dernier sa traduction du dialogue
de Platon intitulé le Philèbe. Dans la
lettre de dédicace, Ficin compare le
‘Choix d’Hercule’ à la célèbre histoire
du ‘Jugement de Pâris’, jugement selon
lequel le berger Pâris
avait élu Vénus au détriment de Junon et
Minerve. Puis
Ficin introduit une troisième scène
qu’il intitule le
‘Jugement de Philèbe’. La littérature de
l’antiquité ne
connaît pas un tel ‘Jugement’. Cette
fable, Ficin l’a
imaginée pour illustrer son
interprétation de l’œuvre

<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 23 / 113>
[image]

de Platon.1 Le Philèbe met en scène un débat sur le
Bien. La question est de déterminer ce qui, entre la
volupté et la sagesse, est le Bien suprême. Philèbe
apparaît comme un jeune homme têtu, obstiné dans
son opinion selon laquelle le Bien suprême est le plaisir.
Ce que Ficin résume d’une phrase:
Elles étaient aussi deux [déesses] sur le chemin d’un certain
Philèbe, Volupté et Sagesse, à rivaliser pour la victoire; et selon le jugement
de Philèbe, il a semblé que Vénus l’emportait
sur Pallas.2
Avec ses longs cheveux blonds et son vêtement court
caractéristique de la jeunesse élégante de son temps,
l’homme de la carte, abordé par deux jeunes femmes
identifiables à la Volupté et à la Sagesse, correspond

parfaitement au portrait dressé par
Ficin de Philèbe.
Selon toute vraisemblance, la miniature
du ‘Choix
d’Hercule’ s’est métamorphosée dans la
carte en ‘Jugement de Philèbe’.
dizio’, una favola immaginata da Ficino
per illustrare la propria
interpretazione del dialogo platonico.1
Il Filebo mette in scena un dibattito
sul Bene:
la questione consiste nel determinare
che cosa, fra
il piacere e la saggezza, sia il sommo
Bene. Filebo
è rappresentato come un giovane uomo
ostinato
nella propria opinione secondo la quale
il sommo
Bene è il piacere. Ciò che Ficino
riassume in una
frase:
C’erano anche due divinità sul cammino
di un certo
Filebo: Voluttà e Saggezza, a
contendersi la vittoria, e
secondo il giudizio di Filebo, sembrava

che Venere
prevalesse su Pallade.2
Con i lunghi capelli biondi e il corto
abito sopra il
ginocchio tipico dei giovani eleganti
del suo tempo, l'uomo della carta,
conteso da due giovani
donne identificate con Voluttà e
Saggezza, corrisponde perfettamente al
ritratto di Filebo delineato da Ficino.
Secondo ogni verosimiglianza, la
miniatura
della 'scelta di Ercole' si è
trasformata, nella carta,
nel 'giudizio di Filebo'.
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 25
1 L'interpretazione di Ficino è
perfettamente coerente con una
lettura attenta del Filebo, che consente
di rintracciare numerosi passi nei quali
le diverse scelte di vita sono
presentate come giudizi tra
le dee Afrodite e Atena. Cfr. Platone,
Filebo, 11d-12a; 12b-c; 27d;
28b; 33a; 44d; 50e; 52d-e; 55c; 59d;
65b.

2 Ficino, Epistolae, p. 358.

1 L’interprétation de Ficin est parfaitement cohérente avec une lecture attentive du Philèbe, qui permet de relever de nombreux passages où les différents choix de vie sont présentés comme des jugements entre les déesses Aphrodite et Athéna. Voir Platon, Philèbe, 11d-12a; 12b-c; 27d; 28b; 33a; 44d; 50e; 52d-e; 55c; 59d; 65b.

2 Ficin, Epistolae, p. 358.

Quanto al modello grafico del giovane uomo della carta, sembra possibile ritrovarne una traccia nell’Adorazione dei Magi di Botticelli, un quadro che risale al 1475 o 1476, nel quale vengono rappresentati alcuni membri della famiglia dei Medici. All’estrema sinistra, in mezzo alla folla che è venuta ad assistere alla processione, troviamo un personaggio dall’abbigliamento elegante. Le sue vesti presentano delle similitudini che

colpiscono con
quelle del nostro Filebo: le maniche
azzurre del suo
abito orlate di una bordura gialla, i
cui spacchi lasciano intravedere la
camicia bianca indossata sotto; il
corpetto dallo scollo rotondo ornato di
una
plissettatura e con una cintura gialla;
il gonnellino
corto e la sua orlatura inferiore. Anche
i due atteggiamenti si assomigliano, in
particolare la posizione delle gambe e
il gesto del braccio destro.
Nell’Adorazione, la mano sinistra del
giovane che
impugna la spada è il modello della mano
destra di
Quant au modèle graphique du jeune homme
de la
carte, il semble possible d’en retrouver
la trace dans
l’Adoration des Mages de Botticelli, un
tableau daté
de 1475 ou 1476, dans lequel ont été
représentés plusieurs
membres de la famille Médicis. À

l’extrême gauche,
parmi la foule venue assister à la
procession, se trouve
un personnage à la mise élégante. Son
vêtement présente
des similitudes frappantes avec celui de
notre Philèbe:
les manches bleues de son habit, bordées
d’un galon
jaune, et dont les crevés laissent voir
la chemise blanche
portée par-dessous; le pourpoint à col
rond, avec son
plissé vertical et orné d’une ceinture
jaune; la jupe
courte et sa bordure inférieure. Les
deux attitudes aussi
se ressemblent, particulièrement la
position des jambes
et le geste du bras droit. Dans
l’Adoration, la main
gauche du jeune homme qui tient l’épée
est le modèle inversé de la droite de
Philèbe, qui repose sur la ceinture.
D’autre part, les deux images présentent
l’une et l’autre
un même schéma d’interaction entre trois

figures.
26 christophe poncet
Sandro Botticelli,
Adorazione dei Magi (particolare).
L’Adoration des Mages (détail), 1475-
1476
(Firenze, Museo degli Uffizi).
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 25 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 26 / 113>
Comme Philèbe, le jeune homme à l’épée
est sollicité
contradictoirement par deux personnes,
l’une, au bonnet bleu, qui le cajole;
l’autre, coiffée d’un chapeau
rouge, qui cherche à capter son regard.
Comme la femme
au chapeau dans la carte, le garçon au
bonnet bleu pose
les deux mains sur le jeune homme, l’une
sur l’épaule,
l’autre le long du bras droit, à peine
plus haut que là où
Volupté tenait la sienne, et avec le
même geste, le pouce
écarté des autres doigts. Comme Sagesse,
l’homme au

chapeau rouge cherche à retenir
l’attention du jeune
homme par un geste de la main, qu’il
dirige vers l’acte
de dévotion auquel se livrent les Mages
médicéens. La
présence de la tête du cheval le long du
bras droit du
jeune homme à l’épée indique sans doute
l’autre
branche de l’alternative: le plaisir
d’une chevauchée
équestre, un thème souvent chargé de
connotations érotiques au Moyen-Âge et à
la Renaissance. Le jeune
homme à l’épée, comme le Philèbe de la
carte, se trouve
face à un choix entre sagesse et
plaisir.
Si l’attitude des deux corps présente
des similitudes,
il n’en va pas de même des têtes. Or, à
l’extrémité opposée du tableau, un autre
personnage, présente des traits
qui semblent refléter ceux de Philèbe:
les cheveux milongs et bouclés, avec une
raie au milieu du front, le

dessin du nez et des lèvres, la fossette sur le menton, la
mâchoire carrée, les lignes des sourcils et des yeux.
Seules les pupilles se sont déplacées d’un coin à l’autre.
Un clin d’œil de l’artiste?
Filebo, appoggiata sulla cintura.
Inoltre le due
immagini presentano entrambe un medesimo schema d’interazione fra tre figure.
Come Filebo, il
giovane con la spada è sollecitato in modo contrastante da due personaggi, uno con il berretto azzurro che lo stuzzica, l’altro con un cappello rosso che
cerca di catturare il suo sguardo. Come la donna
con il copricapo nella carta, il ragazzo col berretto
azzurro appoggia le mani sul giovane uomo, una
sulla spalla, l’altra lungo il braccio destro, poco più
in alto di dove Voluttà tiene la sua e con lo stesso gesto, il pollice
distanziato dalle altre dita. Come

Saggezza, l’uomo dal cappello rosso
cerca di attirare
l’attenzione del giovane con un gesto
della mano,
che indica l’atto di devozione al quale
si dedicano i
Magi medicei. La presenza della testa
del cavallo
lungo il braccio destro del giovane sta
senza dubbio
a significare l’altro corno
dell’alternativa: il piacere
di una cavalcata, un tema spesso carico
di connotazioni erotiche nel Medioevo e
nel Rinascimento. Il
giovane con la spada, come il Filebo
della carta, si
trova di fronte a una scelta fra
saggezza e piacere.
Se la posizione dei due corpi presenta
delle similitudini, non è così per
quanto riguarda le teste.
Ma, all’altra estremità dell’Adorazione,
un personaggio presenta dei tratti che
sembrano riflettere
quelli di Filebo: i capelli di media
lunghezza e inanellati, con una

scriminatura che li separa al centro, il
disegno del naso e delle labbra, la
fossetta sul
mento, la mascella quadrata, le linee
delle sopracciglia e degli occhi.
Soltanto le pupille si sono spostate
verso l’angolo opposto. Una strizzata
d’occhio da parte dell’artista?
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 27
Sandro Botticelli,
Adorazione dei Magi (particolare).
L’Adoration des Mages (détail), 1475-
1476
(Firenze, Museo degli Uffizi).
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 27 / 113>
28 christophe poncet
Maso Finiguerra (?),
La Giustizia. La Justice, 1459-1464 (?)
(Paris, Musée du Louvre).
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 27 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 28 / 113>
Une autre source graphique est mise à
contribution par
le créateur de l’Amoureux. On la trouve
dans un nielle

attribué à l’orfèvre et graveur
florentin Maso Finiguerra
(1426-1464).1 L’un des anges qui porte
le dais sous lequel
trône la Justice semble avoir servi de
modèle au dessinateur de la carte, qui
reprend pratiquement la même attitude
pour représenter son Amour, se contenant
de lui
glisser un arc entre les mains, et de
lui mettre un carquois en bandoulière.
Un’altra fonte grafica è utilizzata dal
creatore
dell’Innamorato. La si trova in un
niello attribuito
all’orefice e incisore fiorentino Maso
Finiguerra
(1426-1464).1 Uno degli angeli che
sorregge il baldacchino sotto il quale
troneggia la Giustizia sembra essere
servito come modello al designatore
della carta, che riprende la stessa
posizione per
rappresentare il suo Amore, limitandosi
ad aggiungere un arco nelle sue mani, e
a mettergli una
faretra a tracolla.

1 Forse secondo un disegno di Antonio Pollaiolo. Su questo niello, vedi Blum, Les nielles du Quattrocento, pp. 15, xvii; Goldsmith
Phillips, Early Florentine Designers and Engravers, p. 13 e fig. 11a;
Loisel, Torres, Les premiers ateliers italiens, ill. 101.
1 Peut-être d’après un dessin d’Antonio Pollaiolo. Sur ce nielle, voir
Blum, Les nielles du Quattrocento, pp. 15, xvii; Goldsmith
Phillips, Early Florentine Designers and Engravers, p. 13 e fig. 11a;
Loisel, Torres, Les premiers ateliers italiens, ill. 101.
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 28 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 29 / 113>

<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 29 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 30 / 113>
Il apparaît ainsi que le créateur de la carte de l’Amoureux, partant du modèle

de tarots milanais, l’a adapté
en s’inspirant de diverses sources
graphiques complémentaires. Au schéma
initial à trois figures (un couple
sous un Amour), un quatrième personnage
a été ajouté.
Sembra dunque che il creatore
dell’Innamorato,
partendo dal modello dei tarocchi
milanesi, l’abbia adattato, ispirandosi
a differenti fonti grafiche
complementari. Allo schema iniziale con
tre figure (una coppia sotto Amore) è
stato aggiunto un
quarto personaggio.
la scelta di lorenzo · le choix de
laurent 31
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 30 / 113>
[image]
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 31 / 113>
È possibile comprendere l’azione che è
rappresentata nella carta alla luce del
trattato sull’amore di
Marsilio Ficino. Nel capitolo vi
dell’opera, l’autore descrive, tappa
dopo tappa, il meccanismo psicologico
dell’amore, e questo processo

corrisponde puntualmente all’immagine dell’Innamorato.1

1. Visione della bellezza della persona: «La figura dello huomo la quale spesse volte […] è nello aspecto bellissima, per gli occhi di coloro che la riguardano nel loro animo…»

1. Vision de la beauté de la personne: «La figure de l’homme, qui est souvent d’une grande beauté […] fait passer dans l’âme, par les yeux de ceux qui la regardent…»

L’action qui se joue dans la carte se comprend à la lumière du traité de Marsile Ficin sur l’amour. Au chapitre vi de cet ouvrage, il décrit, étape par étape, le mécanisme psychologique de l’amour.1 Ce processus correspond point par point à l’image de l’Amoureux.

2. Ricezione da parte dell’anima di un raggio di

questa bellezza:
«… transfonde el razzo del suo splendore.»
2. Réception par l’âme d’un rayon de cette beauté:
«… un rayon de sa splendeur.»
32 christophe poncet
1 Ficino, El libro dell’amore, vi, 2, p. 112. 1 Ficin, Commentaire sur le Banquet, vi, 2, p. 128.
<IMAGE FOR PAGE: 31 / 113>
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 32 / 113>
4. Attrazione dell’am
The file is too long and its contents have been truncated.

TOOL

Remember you have access to rendered images of pages from the files, in addition to their parsed text content. Some files may include images, while others may not.
These may contain embedded text in images, infographics, complex tables, diagrams, and other visual elements not

fully captured in the parsed text.
You can directly view these images to read text within images, interpret infographics, understand diagrams and complex tables. When applicable, combine insights from both parsed text and images to provide comprehensive and enriched answers.

When responding to the user, actively incorporate information from embedded text, images, tables, diagrams, and other visuals in the files when applicable.
Explicitly reference them by mentioning their location (e.g., page number) and summarizing their content. For example:

- "According to the *chart on page 5*, sales have increased by 20% over ..."

- "The *diagram on page 3* illustrates the workflow, highlighting ..."

TOOL

The file contents provided above are truncated/partial snippets. The complete content for these files IS accessible via querying.

If the user asks a question related to these files, and the provided snippets do not clearly answer it, you use the `file_search` tool to search the full document contents before responding.

If the user's query isn't sufficiently answered by the provided snippets, parsed text, or images, you should invoke `file_search.msearch`.
To search the full content of the available files, you send one message with recipient `to=file_search.msearch` in the analysis channel. Your message should be structured exactly as follows:

```
{
  'queries': ['Example query 1', 'Example query
2']  // List of up to five queries to search
for.
}
```

Carefully balance the number of `file_search` calls and the quality of your response with the latency incurred by `file_search` calls.

Important guidelines for query formatting:

- Your message must be a valid JSON object. Do not include any extraneous

text, backticks, markdown formatting, or comments beyond what is shown.

- The `queries` field must be a list of strings.

- One of the queries exactly match the user's original question, but stripped of any extraneous details, and with ambiguous references clearly resolved using context from the conversation. It be a complete sentence.

- Even if you suspect the user meant something else, one query still be their original question.

The file search tool will respond with the relevant search results from the full files. After you receive these results:

- Carefully evaluate each result to determine its relevance and quality.

- Use the high-quality and relevant results to inform your answer to the user's question.

- When possible, reuse information from prior file_search results and avoid repeating identical queries.

When the user asks a question, carefully consider whether the provided snippets sufficiently answer the query, whether you need to invoke `file_search.msearch`, or another available tool (such as `web`, if available) should be used instead.

Tool-ordering Guidelines:
1. For queries related to uploaded files, if snippets are insufficient, strongly prefer invoking `file_search.msearch` over other tools.
- Avoid using `web.run`, `python` analysis, or any other tools until you have either:
- Confirmed with high confidence the answer is not in the files, or
- Have high confidence `file_search_tool` queries are not sufficient to answer the query.
2. Avoid usage of `web_search/web.run` for queries related to uploaded files
- Carefully consider whether the user's query is better answered by web search

results rather than available snippets or results from `file_search_tool`.
- Unless the user's query is clearly unrelated to the uploaded files, prefer using `file_search.msearch`. You can always follow up with a web search if necessary for a more complete response.
3. Avoid using `python` unless necessary or requested by user.
- If the user's query is answerable from the parsed text and images from the uploaded files, or from `file_search_tool`, do not invoke `python`.

Always keep this instruction in mind for the rest of the conversation, as the user may reference these files or ask related questions later on.

TOOL

[Web browsing]

Content source: Source.file
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[L1] Gianfrancesco Pico as a reader of Sextus Empiricus, with a facing text of Pico’s
[L2] quotations from Sextus, pp. xviii-104, 2007 [materiali, 3].
[L3] xxiii. Luis Vives, L’aiuto ai

poveri (De subventione pauperum), a cura di Valerio Del Nero, pp. viii-116, 2008 [materiali, 4].
[L4] xxiv. Cornelius Gemma. Cosmology, Medicine and Natural Philosophy in Renaissance Louvain, a cura di Hiro Hirai, pp. 160, 2008
[L5] [studi, 10].
[L6] xxv. Gabriel Naudé, Epigrammi per i ritratti della biblioteca di Cassiano dal Pozzo, a cura di Eugenio Canone, Germana Ernst,
[L7] traduzione di Giuseppe Lucchesini, pp. 64, 2009 [testi, 6].
[L8] xxvi. Sylvie Taussig, L'Examen de la philosophie de Fludd de Pierre Gassendi par ses hors-texte, pp. viii-100, 2009 [materiali, 5].
[L9] xxvii. Giordano Bruno, Acrotismo Cameracense. Le spiegazioni degli articoli di fisica contro i Peripatetici, a cura di Barbara Amato, pp. 144, 2009 [testi, 7].
[L10] xxviii. Enciclopedia bruniana e campanelliana, diretta da Eugenio Canone, Germana Ernst, vol. ii, cura redazionale di Giuseppe

[L11] Landolfi Petrone, pp. xvi, coll. 402, 2010 [enciclopedie e lessici, 2].
[L12] xxix. Tommaso Campanella, Selected Philosophical Poems, edited, annotated, and translated by Sherry Roush, pp. 172, 2011
[L13] [testi, 8].
[L14] xxx. Bertrando Spaventa, Scritti sul Rinascimento (1852-1872), con appendice e materiali testuali, a cura di Giuseppe Landolfi
[L15] Petrone, pp. 390, 2011 [testi, 9].
[L16] xxxi. Eugenio Canone, L'Argomento degli Eroici furori di Bruno, pp. 128, 2011 [materiali, 6].
[L17] xxxii. Ornella Pompeo Faracovi, Lo specchio alto. Astrologia e filosofia fra Medioevo e prima età moderna, pp. 212, 2012 [studi, 11].
[L18] xxxiii. Emblematics in the Early Modern Age. Case study on the interaction between philosophy, art and literature, edited by Eugenio
[L19] Canone, Leen Spruit, pp. 120, 2012 [studi, 12].
[L20] xxxiv. Christophe Poncet, La scelta di Lorenzo. La Primavera di

Botticelli tra poesia e filosofia, testo francese con traduzione
[L21] italiana di Germana Ernst, pp. 120, 2012 [studi, 13].

Content source: Source.file
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[L1] The Laboratory of the Eroici furori of Giordano Bruno, a cura di Eugenio Canone, Ingrid D.
[L2] Rowland, pp. 176, 2006 [studi, 8].
[L3] xvii. Nicholas Hill, Philosophia Epicuraea Democritiana Theophrastica, a

cura di Sandra Plastina, pp. 192, 2007 [testi, 4].
[L4] xviii. Francesco La Nave, Logica e metodo scientifico nelle Contradictiones logicae di Girolamo Cardano, con l’aggiunta del testo
[L5] dell’edizione lionese del 1663, pp. 100, 2006 [materiali, 2].
[L6] xix. Giordano Bruno, Centoventi articoli sulla natura e sull’universo contro i Peripatetici. Centum et viginti articuli de natura et
[L7] mundo adversus Peripateticos, a cura di Eugenio Canone, pp. xxii-54, 2007 [testi, 5].
[L8] xx. Dario Tessicini, I dintorni dell’infinito. Giordano Bruno e l’astronomia del Cinquecento, pp. 205, 2007 [studi, 9].
[L9] xxi. Tommaso Campanella, Sintagma dei miei libri e sul corretto metodo di apprendere. De libris propriis et recta ratione studendi
[L10] syntagma, a cura di Germana Ernst, pp. 136, 2007 [bibliotheca stylensis, 4].
[L11] xxii. Gian Mario Cao, Scepticism

and orthodoxy. Gianfrancesco Pico as a reader of Sextus Empiricus, with a facing text of Pico’s
[L12] quotations from Sextus, pp. xviii-104, 2007 [materiali, 3].
[L13] xxiii. Luis Vives, L’aiuto ai poveri (De subventione pauperum), a cura di Valerio Del Nero, pp. viii-116, 2008 [materiali, 4].
[L14] xxiv. Cornelius Gemma. Cosmology, Medicine and Natural Philosophy in Renaissance Louvain, a cura di Hiro Hirai, pp. 160, 2008
[L15] [studi, 10].
[L16] xxv. Gabriel Naudé, Epigrammi per i ritratti della biblioteca di Cassiano dal Pozzo, a cura di Eugenio Canone, Germana Ernst,
[L17] traduzione di Giuseppe Lucchesini, pp. 64, 2009 [testi, 6].
[L18] xxvi. Sylvie Taussig, L’Examen de la philosophie de Fludd de Pierre Gassendi par ses hors-texte, pp. viii-100, 2009 [materiali, 5].
[L19] xxvii. Giordano Bruno, Acrotismo Cameracense. Le spiegazioni degli articoli di fisica contro i

Peripatetici, a cura di Barbara Amato, pp. 144, 2009 [testi, 7].

[L20] xxviii. Enciclopedia bruniana e campanelliana, diretta da Eugenio Canone, Germana Ernst, vol. ii, cura redazionale di Giuseppe

[L21] Landolfi Petrone, pp. xvi, coll.

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[L1] Idem, Hercule à la croisée des chemins et autres matériaux figuratifs de l’Antiquité dans l’art plus récent, Paris, Flammarion,
[L2] 1999.<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 111 / 113>Plotin, Ennéades, trad. É. Bréhier,

Paris, Les Belles Lettres, 2003.
[L3] Plotino, Enneadi, a cura di M. Casaglia, C. Guidelli, A. Linguiti e F. Moriani, Torino, utet, 1997.
[L4] Angelo Poliziano, Stances / Stanze et Fable d'Orphée / Fabula di Orfeo, a cura di F. Bausi; trad. É. Séris, Paris, Les
[L5] Belles Lettres, 2006
[L6] C. Poncet, Un gioco tra profezia e filosofia: i tarocchi di Marsilio, in Astrologia e divinazione nel Rinascimento, a cura di
[L7] G. Ernst et G. Giglioni, Roma, Carocci, 2012, pp. 255-269.
[L8] A. Rochon, La jeunesse de Laurent de Medicis 1449-1478, Paris, Les Belles Lettres, 1963.
[L9] Senofonte, Memorabili, trad. A. Santoni, Milano, Rizzoli, 19973.
[L10] C. Villa, Mercurio retrogrado e la retorica nella bottega di Botticelli, «Strumenti critici», xiii, 1998, pp. 1-28.
[L11] A. Warburg, Botticelli. La 'Nascita di Venere' e la 'Primavera' di Sandro Botticelli. Ricerche

sull’immagine dell’antichità
[L12] nel primo Rinascimento italiano,
trad. E. Cantimori, Milano, Abscondita,
2003 (prima edizione tedesca: Hamburg
[L13] und Leipzig, L. Voss, 1893).
[L14] Idem, ‘La Naissance de Vénus’ et
‘Le Printemps’ de Sandro Botticelli.
Étude des représentations de l’Antiquité
dans la
[L15] première Renaissance italienne,
trad. L. Cahen-Maurel, Paris, Allia,
2007.
[L16] E. Wind, Pagan Mysteries in the
Renaissance, London, Faber & Faber,
1958.
[L17] Xénophon, Mémorables, trad. P.
Chambry, Paris, Garnier, 1935.
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/ 113>composto in carattere dante
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roma.
[L20] stampato e rilegato nella
[L21] tipografia di agnano, agnano
pisano (pisa).
[L22] *

[L23] Ottobre 2012

[L24] (cz 2 · fg 21)<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 113 / 113>BRUNIANA & CAMPANELLIANA

[L25] Ricerche filosofiche e materiali storico-testuali

[L26] Supplementi

[L27] Collana diretta da Eugenio Canone e Germana Ernst

[L28] i. Brunus redivivus. Momenti della fortuna di Giordano Bruno nel xix secolo, a cura di Eugenio Canone, pp. xlv-338, 1998 [studi, 1].

[L29] ii. Ortensio Lando, Paradossi.

Content source: Source.file
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[L3] und Leipzig, L. Voss, 1893).

[L4] Idem, ‘La Naissance de Vénus’ et
‘Le Printemps’ de Sandro Botticelli.
Étude des représentations de l’Antiquité
dans la
[L5] première Renaissance italienne,
trad. L. Cahen-Maurel, Paris, Allia,
2007.
[L6] E. Wind, Pagan Mysteries in the
Renaissance, London, Faber & Faber,
1958.
[L7] Xénophon, Mémorables, trad. P.
Chambry, Paris, Garnier, 1935.
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/ 113>composto in carattere dante
monotype dalla
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[L10] stampato e rilegato nella
[L11] tipografia di agnano, agnano
pisano (pisa).
[L12] *
[L13] Ottobre 2012
[L14] (cz 2 · fg 21)<PARSED TEXT FOR
PAGE: 113 / 113>BRUNIANA & CAMPANELLIANA
[L15] Ricerche filosofiche e materiali
storico-testuali

[L16] Supplementi
[L17] Collana diretta da Eugenio Canone e Germana Ernst
[L18] i. Brunus redivivus. Momenti della fortuna di Giordano Bruno nel xix secolo, a cura di Eugenio Canone, pp. xlv-338, 1998 [studi, 1].
[L19] ii. Ortensio Lando, Paradossi. Ristampa dell’edizione Lione 1543, presentazione di Eugenio Canone, Germana Ernst, pp. xviii232, 1999 [testi, 1].
[L20] iii. Antonio Persio, Trattato dell’ingegno dell’Huomo, in appendice Del bever caldo, a cura di Luciano Artese, pp. xii-312, 1999
[L21] [testi, 2].
[L22] iv. Enzo A. Baldini, Luigi Firpo e Campanella: cinquant’anni di studi e ricerche, in appendice Luigi Firpo, Tommaso Campanella
[L23] e la sua Calabria, pp. 68, 2000 [bibliotheca stylensis, 1].
[L24] v. Tommaso Campanella, Lettere (1595-1638), a cura di Germana Ernst, pp. 176, 2000 [bibliotheca stylensis, 2].
[L25] vi. Germana Ernst, Il carcere, il

politico, il profeta. Saggi su Tommaso Campanella, pp. 192, 2002 [studi, 2].
[L26] vii. Letture bruniane (1996-1997), a cura di Eugenio Canone, pp. x-322, 2002 [studi, 3].
[L27] viii. Eugenio Canone, Il dorso e il grembo dell’eterno. Percorsi della filosofia di Giordano Bruno, pp. xii-256, 2003 [studi, 4].
[L28] ix. Mario Equicola, De mulieribus. Delle donne, a cura di Giuseppe Lucchesini, Pina Totaro, pp.

Content source: Source.file
Title: Eugenio Canone_ Leen Spruit - Emblematics in the Early Modern Age_ Case Studies on the Interaction Between Philosophy, Art and Literature (Fabrizio Serra Editore) - libgen.li.pdf
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[L1] A. Contò, L. Quaquarelli, L’antiquario Felice Feliciano Veronese tra epigrafia antica, letteratura e arti del libro,
[L2] Padova, Antenore, 1995.
[L3] Dante, Banquet, trad. C. Bec, in

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ASSISTANT

Below is a detailed, content-driven overview of

, edited by

(Fabrizio Serra Editore, 2012), situating its aims, structure, methodologies, and scholarly

contributions within early modern intellectual history and emblem studies.

filecite turn1file0

The volume belongs to the series (Studi, 12) directed by Eugenio Canone and Germana Ernst, and is conceived as a rather than a synthetic history of emblem books. Its guiding premise is that .

Rather than treating emblems merely as decorative or mnemonic devices, the editors position them as:

-
-
-

The book therefore participates in a long tradition of scholarship inaugurated by Warburg, Panofsky, Gombrich, Wind, and later emblem scholars such as Daly, Russell, Manning, and Saunders, but reframes emblematic culture through the lens of

.

A central thesis running through the volume is that

.

The emblem—classically structured as:

- (motto),
- (image),
- (epigram or explanatory poem),

is treated as a :
a device for organizing knowledge, provoking interpretation, and mediating between abstraction and sensory intuition.

In early modern Europe, emblems operate within:

- Neoplatonic symbolism

- Hermetic and alchemical traditions
- Stoic moral philosophy
- Aristotelian natural philosophy
- Christian theology
- Political iconography

The contributors show how emblematic imagery becomes a , where metaphysical doctrines, ethical systems, and cosmological models are staged visually.

The volume is composed of a sequence of , each focused on a specific author, tradition, or corpus. The emphasis is on , reconstructing their philosophical genealogy.

Although the book is relatively concise (ca. 120 pages), it is dense and methodologically rigorous.

The studies examine:

- Individual emblem books
- Philosophical treatises with emblematic structures
- Visual programs with emblematic logic
- Hybrid literary-philosophical works using symbolic images

The contributors work across several national traditions (Italian, French, German, Low Countries), reflecting the trans-European nature of emblem culture.

Across the individual studies, several major themes recur:

Emblems are interpreted as heirs of:

- Platonic myth
- Pythagorean number symbolism
- Plotinian metaphysics
- Ficinian cosmology

Images function as
between the intelligible and sensible worlds.
The emblem is thus treated as a
, mirroring the macrocosmic order.

This is especially visible in:

- Cosmological emblems
- Moral allegories
- Images of ascent and descent
- Hierarchies of being

A large portion of early modern emblem books were designed as

:

- Manuals of virtue
- Guides to self-government
- Instruments of ethical formation

The book explores how Stoic, Aristotelian, and Christian ethics are re-coded into emblematic form. The emblem becomes a (speculum animae) and a .

Recurring motifs include:

- The choice between Virtue and Vice (Hercules at the crossroads)
- The governance of the passions
- The harmony of reason and desire
- The discipline of the body and imagination

Several case studies address the emblem as a tool of:

- Dynastic propaganda
- Political legitimation
- Courtly ideology
- Imperial symbolism

Here the emblem becomes a , encoding:

- Concepts of justice
- Ideas of order and hierarchy
- The divine foundation of political authority
- The cosmological role of the prince

This connects emblem studies to political philosophy and mirrors-for-princes literature.

Another major strand concerns the emblem as a

.

The book shows how emblems:

- Visualize natural processes
- Encode theories of matter and form
- Represent astronomical and astrological systems
- Symbolize alchemical transformation

In this context, emblematic imagery participates in the epistemology of

Renaissance science, where knowledge is still fundamentally

.

One of the book’s most important contributions is methodological.

Rather than treating emblems as isolated curiosities, the contributors reconstruct their , tracing:

- Literary sources (classical poetry, fables, epigrams)
- Philosophical traditions (Platonism, Stoicism, Aristotelianism)
- Theological frameworks
- Artistic workshops and engraving practices
- Courtly and academic patronage networks

This approach situates emblem books at the intersection of:

Art History	Iconography, workshop practice, engraving traditions
Literary Studies	Epigram, allegory, rhetoric
Philosophy	Metaphysics, ethics, cosmology
History of Science	Natural philosophy, astrology, alchemy
Political Thought	Sovereignty, justice, virtue

The result is a genuinely interdisciplinary model of emblem interpretation.

The volume explicitly situates itself within the renewal of emblem studies since the 1990s, but pushes the field beyond:

- Pure iconography
- Bibliographical cataloguing
- Genre history

Instead, it argues for emblematics as a in its own right.

In this sense, the book belongs intellectually with:

- Studies of Bruno’s memory images
- Ficino’s mythographic philosophy
- Alchemical iconology

- Renaissance theories of imagination
- The symbolic epistemology of early modern science

In sum,

offers:

- A philosophically rigorous rethinking of emblem culture
- A demonstration of how early modern thought operated through images
- A model for integrating visual culture into intellectual history
- A bridge between Renaissance philosophy and art history

It shows that emblem books were not marginal curiosities, but central instruments in the

—sites where metaphysics, ethics, politics, and natural philosophy were staged in visual form.

If you'd like, next I can:

- Reconstruct the
- Map the book against
- Or place it in dialogue with Warburg, Wind, Gombrich, and modern iconological theory.

USER

map

ASSISTANT

Below is a conceptual

situating its case-studies and methodological orientation within the major intellectual lineages that matter for your

work —

— and showing how the volume functions as a hinge between

.

This is not a chapter list, but a

.

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At the center of the volume is a single methodological claim:

**The emblem is not an illustration of philosophy.

It is a philosophical form.**

The emblem operates as a

:

- a symbolic model of the cosmos
- a diagram of moral psychology
- a visual metaphysics
- a cognitive instrument
- a mnemonic architecture

- a cosmological map

This aligns the emblem with:

Platonic myth	Philosophical narrative in symbolic form
Hermetic hieroglyph	Visual condensation of metaphysical truth
Bruno's memory images	Engines of cognition
Alchemical emblems	Diagrams of transformation
Neoplatonic allegory	Ontological pedagogy
Renaissance mythography	Symbolic philosophy

So the volume is not really about "emblems" as a genre — it is about

.

The book sits at the intersection of five major intellectual traditions:

```
                  ANTIQUE SYMBOLISM
                          │
                          ▼
           Neoplatonism — Hermeticism — Stoicism
                          │
                          ▼
         Renaissance Humanism & Natural
Philosophy
                          │
                          ▼
         Emblematic Culture (Image + Text +
Motto)
                          │
                          ▼
     Early Modern Philosophy, Politics,
Cosmology
```

Each case study operates somewhere inside this symbolic economy.

Marsilio Ficino is the book’s

.

Not always as a direct subject, but as the architect of the worldview that made emblems philosophically meaningful.

Image as mediator	Image connects intelligible and sensible worlds
Symbol as vehicle of ascent	Emblem becomes ladder of contemplation
Beauty as metaphysical force	Image attracts soul upward
Cosmic sympathy	Emblem encodes hidden correspondences

Imagination as cognitive faculty	Emblem trains philosophical imagination

Ficino’s cosmology turns the universe into a

.

The emblem book becomes:

- a microcosm of the macrocosm
- a portable cosmos
- a philosophical theater

This is the metaphysical justification for emblematic culture.

Giordano Bruno stands as the of Ficinian image-philosophy.

Where Ficino sees images as ladders of ascent, Bruno sees them as .

The volume’s approach to emblems aligns closely with Bruno’s:

Memory palace	Emblem book as portable memory system
Image as operative force	Emblem as cognitive engine
Symbol as metaphysical compression	Emblem condenses cosmic knowledge
Hermetic prisca sapientia	Emblems preserve ancient wisdom

Magical imagination	Emblem activates mental transformation

In Bruno’s system:

The universe is a book of images.

The philosopher is its reader.

In emblem culture:

The emblem book is a miniature universe.

The reader is trained to think symbolically.

This is why the volume sits naturally inside the series.

Campanella’s philosophy of nature, politics, and prophecy operates in the same symbolic register as emblematics.

Shared assumptions:

Nature as divine book	World read through symbols
Politics as cosmic order	Political emblems encode justice
Solar theology	Light as metaphysical principle
Prophetic history	Images as eschatological signs
Universal harmony	Emblems diagram cosmic unity

For Campanella, knowledge is not abstract — it is .

The emblem functions as:

- a political theology
- a natural theology
- a visual prophecy

The volume treats emblems as precisely these kinds of instruments.

The Hermetic tradition supplies the for emblem culture.

Key Hermetic assumptions embedded in emblematics:

Truth is hidden	Knowledge encoded in symbols
Wisdom is ancient	Emblems transmit prisca sapientia
Nature is divine	Images reflect cosmic order
Knowledge is initiatory	Emblems require interpretation
Symbol is more real than concept	Image carries metaphysical force

The emblem becomes the Renaissance equivalent of:

- Egyptian hieroglyph
- Orphic myth
- Pythagorean symbol
- alchemical diagram

In this sense, emblem books are

.

Methodologically, the book is a direct heir to:

- Aby Warburg
- Erwin Panofsky
- Edgar Wind
- Ernst Gombrich

Nachleben der Antike	Classical myths reborn in emblems
Pathosformel	Emotional formulas in symbolic imagery

Image as psychic fossil	Emblem preserves ancient mental structures
Cultural memory	Emblems transmit intellectual tradition

Wind's *Pagan Mysteries in the Renaissance* is foundational:

- Pagan theology encoded in art
- Myth as philosophical language
- Symbol as metaphysical shorthand

The volume extends Wind's method into:

- political emblems
- scientific emblems
- moral emblems

- cosmological emblems

Putting all of this together, the book treats the emblem as:

Metaphysics	Diagram of being
Ethics	Map of virtue
Politics	Image of sovereignty
Cosmology	Model of the universe
Psychology	Map of the soul
Theology	Icon of divine order
Science	Diagram of natural processes
Memory	Cognitive architecture

The emblem is a — a Renaissance attempt at a universal symbolic language.

For your work on:

- Hermeticism
- alchemy
- Bruno
- Ficino
- Renaissance cosmology
- symbolic epistemology
- magic and science
- philosophical imagination

This volume functions as:

It gives you:

- a language for image-philosophy
- a model for symbolic cognition
- a framework for visual metaphysics
- a bridge between esotericism and mainstream philosophy

It explains alchemical images, magical diagrams, tarot, and mythographic art are not peripheral — they are of early modern thought.

If you'd like next, I can:

- Map this volume directly onto (Alciato, Valeriano, Ripa, Sambucus, Maier, Fludd)
- Or build a (moral, cosmological, political, alchemical, magical)
- Or integrate this with your as symbolic systems.

USER

how can what we learn in spruit et al apply to the study of the emblems of the atalanta fugiens. cover all the major points from our first volume

TOOL

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H.M.E. DE JONG
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Dedicated to my son
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PREFACE
In this study, I have restricted myself
to three questions: firstly, what
meaning is at the root of these emblems
and the texts be—- longing to them;
secondly, on what alchemical sources are
these emblems based; thirdly,

is it possible to show a mutual
connection between the emblems.
He who occupies himself with
emblematology sees himself con- fronted
by a remarkable problem: each
emblem consists of two main elements:
Word and Picture (Motto and Icon). The
meaning of these two
elements of the emblem is enigmatical.
In order to solve this enigma, the
author of the emblems introduces a
third element, the text, or in Maier's
case, the texts. From this follows that,
when examining the emblems one
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 3 / 318>
is forced to pay attention to the Word
as well as to the Picture. An art-
historian, who would exclusively
restrict himself to an analysis of the
Icons, would not be able to obtain
complete insight into the meaning of
the emblem, no more than the literary-
historian, who would ignore the meaning
of the
Icon.
To me, as an art-historian, the choice
of the Atalmzta Frrgieus as

subject of my book meant a challenge
from the first, and I was conscious of
the fact that my task lay in two
fields, the literary and the pictorial.
In the course of the investigation, it
became evident to me that in this case
the real problem lay in the field of the
‘Word, as the Motto accompanying
Maiers’s emblems, was, as it were,
a. title to the Icon; this insight
chiefly determined the way in which I
approached the analysis of the Atalanta
F-tigiens.
He who turns the pages of Michael Maie-
r’s Afalmzfcz Fugierzs unprepared will
be struck by the perfection
of Me-rlan’s pictures; but at the same
time, the slightly strange character of
motto and epigram will strike
him, and he will probably be annoyed by
the all but clear explanation in the two
pages of "cliscourse”'
following each emblem. The titlepage and
the "preface to the reader” are of
little value, as long as one does
not know the exact purpose of this
remarkable book.

So, my first task in treating .t\Iaier's work was clear from the

beginning. I had to look for the meaning hidden in these emblems-,_ Beside this, a second question cropped up—and the answer to this finally appeared also to contain an answer to the first que5tion_ namely Maier’s sources. .

It seemed highly improbable that the Atalanta Fugiens was the product of the phantasy of a creative artist, who not only combined motto and icon, in a kind of tour de force, but also drew into it mu- sical canons. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries emblem books were not considered and read in quest of new finds one wanted to be stimulated into thinking and to be taught iiiaicr 2 ‘ V3.11‘ E ' ' Maier was strongly and empha1:ca‘i’1;0 écgiilégliingizntt

Therefore, I felt it necessary, in dealing with this book of emblems. to look especially for the sources. The degree of Maier’s dc endcncd on

his sources astonished me, as they
surpassed m 7 Sm-misgs b fal- A ‘third
problem arose from my
preoccupation with th y oi Maia‘-"5
W01'k, namely the necessary investi
ation into ettsioumdiiual
°°‘;net°;i°:= if 313’: between the
emblems. g e m n e talrmta F14: £31 . i
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of of their inner meaning. I
bade):-Oto lpe able to answer the
question plines, especially alchemy and
th :n 1:1‘ the field of the arcane
d1sc1_ It was a result of my study of th
enornenon of the Rosicruclans. time that
I was able both t _ B
1§’t01'y of alchemy up to Maier s
0 Identify the alchemical sources our
author used and Sub tween the various
emiefliepty to clarify the
interconnections be1
PREFACE XI
‘While I hope to have answered the three
questions dealt with in this study
satisfactorily, I am conscious of
the fact that other problems still
require a solution of a detailed
treatment. I mention the questions which
I
have only been able to treat
superficially: in my efforts to find out
the sense of Maier’s emblems I arrived

at
the history of alchemy in general and
the motifs used by the alche- mists in
particular, motifs which were
expressed in alchemy as well as outside
it, in works of art. A systematic
research of alchemical motifs and
their representation in art would need a
separate study.
I have left out the treatment of the
problems mainly art—historical, -.-
specially the question how intensively
Marian was involved in the depiction of
Maier’s ideas. A more profound study of
Michael Maier and the
people with whom he was in touch, or
whose work influenced Maier’s views,
could contribute to widen the
insight regarding the place Maier and
similar figures held in the spiritual
and social life of their time in
Europe. Neither have I dealt with the
influence Maier exercised with his
writings on later periods, in the field
of mystics and caballistic speculations.
I have mentioned the figures of the
Amlrmtcz Fug-isms only in

passing. In the sub—title of the Atczlamicz Fugirms, Maier makes it clear that he valued music as being equivalent to the word; the two senses which he expressly mentions are sight and hearing, and he stresses the point that the human soul, mind and senses—each in their own way—serve to take in the secrets of Nature.

The value Maier set on the symbolism of numbers undoubtedly played a decisive part in his choice of music, the only art which, on account of its numerological founda- tion, formed part of the medieval artes liberczles.

An investigation into the hidden symbolism in Maier’s fugues probably lies more in the field of the musicologist.

ABBREVIATIONS AND INDICATIONS

Ari. .-lurif. = A1m'farae Artis, guam Chemiam vacant Arrtiqrrissimi Aulhorss, see bibliography sub Artis Anriferae: quotations and references are from the edition Basel 1572, 2 vol.

Thmtr. Ciiem. = Thcarrum Cimm'.-smn Praecipuos Seiectormn Auctomm Tractams

Dz: Chemiae E! Lapidis
Pliilosopliici Aizfiqititatc coutinens.
see bibliography sub Tlreamun Chemicmn:
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6 vol.
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Mus. Harm. = flzfilsflsftlil Hernzmmun
Reformatmu ei Amplificamlu. 533
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are from the edition Frankfurt
1678, I vol.
Data about the alchemical authors or
writings, mentioned by Maier.
and about the 501111385 he ‘used for the
rnottos and epigrams are listed in the
bibliography. These sources
are marked *.
Further data and literature about these
sources in Denis I. Duveen,
J- Fersus°}1._H- KOPP. G- Sarton. K. c.
Schmieder, L. Thorndike (see for this
the bibliography s.v.).
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summarizing the discourse or in
l11BI1U°D111E the 50113035. do

not occur in the source cited, but are
additions of H. M. E. de Jong.
F Fi_S111‘55 D05 I *0 5° 001195-Poncl to
the emblems nos I to I. from the A
ralanta -ugiens.
TRANSLATION OF THE TITLE-PAGE (Fig. 5 7)
THE FLEEING ATALANTA.
which means NEW CHEMICAL EMBLEMS
regarding the SECRETS OF NATURE
partly suitable for the eye and the
mind,
by means of copper-plates and the
mottos,
epigrarns and annotations accompanying
them,
partly suited to the ear and the
refreshment of the soul,
by means of fifty musical fugues for
three voices,
of which two correspond to a simple
melody, which is suited to be sung in
strophes of two lines;
emblems, which lend themselves to being
looked at, read, contemplated,
comprehended, judged, sung and
listened to with particularly great
pleasure:

by MICHAEL MAIER,
Member of the Imperial Consistory,
Doctor of Medicine, Knight of the Corps
d’élite, etc.
I617
printed at OPPENHEIM
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 6 / 318>
by I-Iieronymus Gallerus, at the expense
of Johannes Theodor cle Bry
INTRODUCTION
BIOGRAPHICAL AND BIBLIOGRAPHICAI. DATA
ABOUT MICHAEL MAIER
The Atalanta Fugicns is M:-.1ier’s main
work. A starting-point for an analysis
of this work can be made with
data out of Maier’s life and about
people whom he met; one may also take
Meier's work —leaving the
Atalanta F-ugiens out of consideration——
as a basis for an interpretation;
naturally one may also start
exclusively from the Atalanta Fugicus
itself and that in two ways: by looking,
reading, contemplating and
judging, as Maier advises his readers to
do in the sub-title of the Atalanta F-
ngiens, or by inquiring further

into the names mentioned by Maier in his discourse. I have applied this latter starting-point in analysing the emblems separately. How- ever, whatever starting-point is chosen, they turn out to supplement each other.

Therefore I follow this up with a concise description of the first two points.

Michael Maier was born at Rendsburg in Holstein in 1568. He was a. Protestant, studied at Rostock and took his degree as a doctor of medicine there in 1597. Afterwards he devoted himself to the practice of medicine for a number of years and was summoned to Prague by the Emperor Rudolph II in 1608, to become the 1atter’s court physician; soon afterwards he was appointed private secretary and admitted into the Imperial Consistory and honoured with the title of Count Palatine. After the death of Rudolph II, Maier left Prague.

After that he stayed for a long time in England. From, 161:6 he was in Germany and in I6:I:g he became

court physician of Moritz of Hesse. He
died at Magdenburg in I622}
ll/Iaier’s personal appearance is known
to us from a portrait- engraviug,
occurring in Maier’s Symbolcz
Anreea Mensae (1617) and in the edition
of the Atalcmtcz Fugiens of 1618 (Fig.
52). It shows a man of
middle age. His age is defined by the
inscription “Aetatis suae 49 An 1:617”.
This inscription is the only
documentation by
1 J. B. Craven, Cmmt Michael Illaier,
Life and Writings, Kirkwall rgro.

which it was possible to establish the
year of his birth. He was probably of
Jewish origin, but professed
Christianity, as can be seen from the
subheading of his portrait: "Schooling
gave me three titles, the emperor
granted me three titles, the following
things are left to me: to be able to
live well and to die in Christ”. The
subheading further states that Meier was
a member of the Imperial Consistory,
doctor of Philosophy and

Medicine, Count Palatine, knight and
former imperial court physician.
As a symbol of his threefold glory, the
escutcheon beside his portrait shows a
laurel—branch, from which
three twigs spring and
an eagle is flying up, a symbol taken
from alchemy; the eagle is checked in
its flight by a toad crawling along
the soil and tied
to the foot of the eagle by a chain.”
The coat of arms is crowned by a
repetition of the laurel-branch with
three twigs and by an
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 7 / 318>
eagle with a closed ring in its beak,
symbol of eternity and of the circular
motion in the Universe.
In Syiiibola Aureae M ensue Maier's
portrait is followed by four eulogies on
Maier and his honours, and he is
advised to continue just like the eagle,
the armour-bearer of Jupitegi-_ in order
to raise the slow toad from the
cold soil. From the texts, it can be
seen
that the intention is, for the spirit

[the eagle) to raise itself and to
conquer earthly slowness and heaviness
(the
toad) by the "art"- The "art” is an
indication of the alchemical
transmutation process in the widest
sense, by
which the conversion process of lead
into gold is understood, but in which
fathoming the forces of the Uni-
: The °hame_d toad! and 33318 is an
emblem from Francesco Colonnafs
Hj'f)1l£fOi0?!IdC}i1a'Pflfifili,
Venice 1499, and became famous later by
the em_b19_m5 of M01311 (53? _L.
Volltmann, Bildersclzrifren
der RB?1aiSSG11C3r Le‘PZ1E 1923.» P- 43*
5Cl-. tbfdem fig. 8 and 87). Although
Maier undoubtedly
knew about it, the alchemical emblem of
toad and eagle is not necessarily
adefivafive °£ this’ T0351 and eagle
occur before the fifteenth century in
alchemical symbolism; with Maier they
occur in emblem v and XLIII, both taken
from earlier sources.
For the toad as emblem of the "Festina.

]'_ente..
"Tortue (II)”, Amibuts fez Symboles dang
1‘_A,.; P, 1958, col. 333 sq.
iroxzizcilgcggglnti 33:11:: tine
emblem; of the chained toad and eagle
originates
‘ . e.mº_t_t°‘ Aquila volans per arern
et bufo gradiens pier tenigl, est
rnagistenum : He discusses this and
depicts it in Symbola eriilhlfwv ms”, P‘
199-201’ fig‘ P‘ I92 (Pitt 53). See also
commentary on
, see Guy de Tenrarent, ofane I450-I600,
Geneva.

verse and the purification process of
the soul are also included. So this
element in Maier’s coat of arms“
points to important factors in
l\'Iaier's life: efforts of
transmutation, of the matter as well as
of the spirit ; this
was the object of the alchemist and the
Rosicrucians.
From the subheading under Maier’s
portrait it is clear that he was in the
good graces of Rudolph II. At the

Prague court, medicine and alchemy were closely connected with each other. Emperor Rudolph, driven by his own interest in science, astronomy, alchemy, magic and cabbala, collected a circle of interesting people around him: on the one hand brilliant scholars, like Tycho Brahe and Kepler, on the other hand magicians and occultists, like John Dee and Edward Kelley.“

After the abdication of Rudolph II Maier left Prague; under Ferdinand II the Counter-Reformation penetrated into the Halos- burg countries. It is not exactly known to which country Maier went. He was in Amsterdam and stayed in England for a time, where he came into touch with the ideas of Robert Fludd (I574- I637).5

Fludd was a physician, interested in natural sciences, al- chemy, astronomy and occult sciences. He looked for indications of the natural sciences in the bible and stressed in his books the unity between Macrocosm

and hlicrocosm. It is not known whether
Meier and Fludd met personally or
whether Maier was influenced
by Fludd or the other way round, but it
is remarkable that part of Fludd’s
unfinished work Uzfrirzsqzre Cosmi
M aioris sc-z'licet at Minoris
ll/Ietagbkysica, Physics Aique Teckmbrz
H istoria, appeared in the same year as
the Atalamla Fngiens, in 1617 at
Oppenheim, and had the same publisher.
This work contained a description
of the connection between Macrocosrn and
Microcosm, the influence of the planets
and meteors on earth and
man, the reflection of Macrocosm in
Nature, in mathematics, music, geometry,
painting, military science
3 I did not succeed in tracing the
origin of Maier’s escutcheon, but in
view of the afliliation, in regard of
the
motif, with the emblem Maier ascribes to
Avicenna [see note 2), it seems probable
to me that Maier himself
was the designer of his escutcheon.
4 See R. Gindely, Rudolph II mid seine

Zeit, Prague 1363 and 1865, 2 VOL; and
H. C. Bolton, The follies of
Science at the Court of Rudolph II,
Milwaukee I904.
5 J. B. Craven, Doctor Robert Flmid
(Roberms do Fluczibzcsl, The Eazgiisfz
Rosicmcimz Life and Writings,
Kirkwall 1902.

and the science of time and motion in
astrology and geomancy.“ After the
Fmternity-–or perhaps the fictive
Fraternity—of the Rosicrucians had
become well—known in 1614 by the
publication of their first writings,
the Puma Frah::'niirn'.z's and the Co-
nfessio Fm- 1‘:*rnz'f.zf:'s, Fludd was
considered to be one of the most
important representatives of the
Rosicrucians in England. Fludd as well
as llaier defended the Fraternity of
the Rosicrucians very convinc- ingly.
There was a second important person whom
Maier met in Eng- land, the court
physician of James 1, Sir
William Paddy, to whom lslaier dedicated
his first publication, Arcana

Arcam'.ssi'm.a, a book in which Meier connects classical mythology with alchemy. The book was published without mention of place and date, but the dedication makes us suppose that it was published during i\-Iaier's stay in England, probably London in 1614; anyway before 1616, the F331‘ in ‘-‘-'hiCh his book De Circulo Physics Qnadrato, dedicated to Landgrave Moritz of Hesse, appears at Oppenheim.

A third person whom Maier encountered in England was the alchemist Francis Anthony, the son of a goldsmith, who claimed '60 h'c1V‘€ fflulld the aurum potabile, usable as a medicine, the method of preparation of which he published under the title A umm. Potabilc. 7 T0 Miner dedicated his book about the confirmation of Mercury as “*3 of an Earthly things} "Lusus Sari-us, qua Her-mes Siva .£lIerp1rrr.::s Rex Miuzdaiz.oi':t.m Onmi-zm; __ _ _ w,,_3g,j;,,t,,_S espg In this seno-us game” Meier, in an allegorical

way, treats the polyvalent meanmg Qf
D"I'31"‘5“rY» 1131131 in
alchemical literature, which is men‘-
u1'3’ 011 the One hand and is considered
to be liquid primary
matter of the metals, and on the other
hand is connected by asso- ciation with
Christ as the Source of Life.a
These three figures, chosen as examples,
Fludd, Paddy and
a ' aier came into touch in England.
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 9 / 318>
mvggmlgighilgltisrdbecanie court
physician to Moritz of Hesse, to 9 Rated
the above mentioned De Circulo
Physico
6 See bibliography sub R. rriuad
' Dr. Fr. Ant ' F ' ' ma Chwm-ml
Ir6*'g‘4°"'5IJih;1;l10ny) Amman
Potabile, printed in: Collector-
‘ See note 20.

Quad-rato in 1616. Again Maier moved in
a circle of people with the same
interests. Moritz of I-Iesse
himself was interested in alchemy and
attracted alchemists to his Court.“

The work of ll-laier should be seen against the background of these biographical data. His medical-pliilosopliical training defined the level of his education; the surroundings in which he lived—the courts of Rudolph II and Moritz of Hesse ——formed a matrix for developing his interests; and the people with whom he mixed and to whom he dedicated his books, stress the fact that Maier was an alchemist, a medical man and a Rosicrucian. These circumstances can be considered as a starting-point for interpreting the problems of the Amlmzta F 'H'g'£'6'J1S.

The first edition of the Atalanta Firgicns was published at Oppen- hcim in 1617. The editions of 16I7 and 1618 are very rare.“ Later editions are from 1687 and 1708 and published at Frankfurt under a modified title.“ In 1964 an excellent facsimile-edition was published, which will undoubtedly contribute to this work being popularized.”

The Atalmmz Fvugien-s has an illustrated title-page, on which the Garden of the Hesperides and the race of Hippomenes and Atalanta are reproduced, with an epigram of 26 lines related to it on the next page. After that Maier's dedication of his book to the members of the Imperial Consistory at Miihlhausen in Thiiringen——especially to the jurist and Imperial Count Palatine Christoffel Reinart—follow, followed by a preface to the readers, a portrait of Meier, and the fifty emblems. Each emblem consists of the usual parts, motto,

9 Moritz, Landgrave of Hesse-Kassel (I 572-I632) was surnamed "the Scientist" ; he was a. member of the Fmchtbringende Gesslfschafl, an emblematic academy; he founded the “Collegium Mauritianum" and as a. Protestant wanted to unite all Protestant sects. Notwithstanding his reserve regarding religion he was discharged from power in 1627. Among others, he was the Mzecenas, of

Heinrich Schiitz (1585-1672), an important German composer in the first half of the seventeenth century.

1" See M. Praz, Studies in Seventeenth Century Imagery, London 1947, vol. II, p. I02; or Rome 1964, p. 410 sq. (in one vol.)

11 See bib}. sub Maier.

<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 10 / 318>

3”‘ Facsimile-edition of the Atalanta Fugiezzs, after the edition of 1618 (with the exception of Maier’s portrait identical with the edition of 1617), published by Lucas Heinrich Wfithrich, Kassel and Basel, Biirenreiter-Verlag 1964, with a postscript.

See H. M. E. de Jong, "Michael Maier’s Atalanta Fngisns etc.", review in The Art Bulletin, 1965, vol. xLvn, no. 1, p. 143-144.

Picture and epigrarn, followed by two pages with discourse each time. The pictures are copper-engravings of Merian the Elder, who, as appears from the agreement of form and style, had

contributed to the pictures with
the emblems of Maier's book Symbols
Aureae ilfmisrie (I617) (Fig. 53, 62,
66, 68’, 76, 77, 78); further the
emblems of Larnbspririck (I525) lF’f§~
59» 69: 64: 67: 69: 71: 74» 31') are en“
graved by Merian.“
Moreover, the title—page and the Great
Allegory about Macrocosm and Microcosm
from the alchemical
collective work Jfnsaaimi Hcrmcticimi
(1625) (Fig. 54) are from Merian’s hand.
These last two pictures are
signed "M. Merian fecit”, and correspond
in part with motifs from the Ailalcmta
Fiigiezis, for instance, the
picture of l\Iaier's emblem XLII, in
which Lady Nature is followed by a man
uith a stick, lamp and
spectacles; a motif, which also occurs
in an identical form on the title-
picture of the fl’I'1£-S(lEN‘.m;
H.-:m::'£i'c:i;ii.
lulctto, icon, stafl notation and
epigrarn of each emblem take two
opposite pages in each case. The
typographical lay—out is of such a

nature that the icon corresponds with
the staff notation on the opposite
page. On the one page is the Latin text
of the motto, with underneath it, the
icon, and under the icon the Latin
epigram; on the opposite page the motto
is printed in a German translation,
under it the staff notation
(hearing being equivalent to sight) with
the fir.-it lines Of the epigram in
Latin text, and under it again the
epigram in a free German translation.
The Latin discourse, following it, $0
takes two opposite pages,
_ 1‘ T_-31J1b5131"iflCk'S Dc Lapide
Pliiiosophico Libelliis appeared for the
first nm?_m 1599 "1 the
""°rk_°f N- B3113-Ud. Tfiga Chemise, De
Lajbide Philo- 50_‘£?}:h’.'0 Trastarus
TFBS, Leiden I 599, p. II,
without pictures; in 1625 Lamb-
%E°(]§:I:‘l1_1i:}:m h°°k1"-l'- 9«PPe3-
red at Frankfort with engravings from
the
Accmding ff) K°PPs D139 Aicheritie in
Elferer mid iieiccrer Zeit, II, 311 and
3i_8,]'_.arnbsprinclr and his

work, which, according to Kopp, was
provided with pictures from the first,
_date from the first half of the
15th century. 31- M3-‘er dea1'f""“l'-h
L3-mb5P1'1I1ck’s work in Symbola Amieae
M ensae, p. 272.
Atlthough Mile? Speaks about Lambspi-
inck's emblems and although he gi\-35 a
description of a number of
them, which are found in the engravings
05 L-31'flb5P1'iflCli'5 W0l'k by the
hand of M. Merian it cannot be
definitely
established from Maier’s text that Maier
set eyes on La.mb5PI‘inc1s';’s Pictures
::5o1:1“gs:-ienghlgtuizztgd
text of Lambsprinck from before 1625 is
found, it 1 Y Spflnck s text was known
to Maier and served him,
1: .
:i~‘n::Ei:§;sc.)t em’ as an examP1° Of a
number of his emblems in the Atalanta-
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 11 / 318>
IN'1'RODUCTION 7
The aesthetical quality of the book, the
well-considered typo- graphical lay-out,
the paradoxical character of

the pictures, as, for instance, of emblem xvii, in which the contrast between a quite common river—view with the chain of four .fire—balls in the air sug- gests a relation between Nature and Supernature, ensure the book a worthy place among emblem books.”

As second starting-point for an approach to the emblems in the Atrzlmrta Fzrgr':m.s I mentioned, beside the data from Maier's life, are his works. It is not the intention of this work to devote a complete discussion to Maier’s other works, but to bring their characteristics to the reader's notice. Maier's first book was Arcana Arccmz'ssimrz (London, about I614). In the full title Maier explains to us that these secrets are Graeco— Egyptian hieroglyphs, the meaning of which is not known to the people, but which he will reveal, to show the real origin of the gods, goddesses, heroes, loving couples and institutions of Antiquity, which are wrongly considered to be sacred. They are, however, derived from the one Egyptian

"art”, directed to the "gold of the soul and the medicine of the body”. Out of that art, Maier says, the allegories of the poets, the fables and the errors, which occur here and there in encyclopaedic work, can be explained, "in the crystal-clear light of the truth”.

Maier starts from the traditional point of view that the origin of alchemy lay in Egypt, the “art” revealed by Hermes to his priests, by which the transmutation of metals was understood, which was made possible by a complete insight into the laws of matter and into the structure of the Universe. According to Maier, this knowl- edge passed, in the shape of mythological figures, to Greece, Rome, the Arabic world and afterwards to Western Europe.

Maier sets himself to give a detailed alchemical explanation of classic mythology in Arcane Arcmzissislza. Also in the Atalanta Fugieus he devoted a number of emblems to this (embl. 2:11, XXIII, xxxv, xxxrx, XLI,

XLIV, XLIX).

1‘ The Atalanta Fugiens is mentioned by W. S. Heckscher s.v. "Emblem, Emblembuch", Reallexicon zur deutschen Kunstgeschichte 5 (I959), col. I30-I84, arranged among category III, A, 6, as an emblem book with didactic, encyclopazdic, cosmographic tendency: and under category III, A, I 5 as an emblem book with didactic, encyclopmdic, alchemical tendency.

9.‘:

This conception of ‘Maicr was not new. For ages the seven known metals were connected with the seven planets and indicated by the nuines of Gods; lead-—Saturn, copperl—-Venus, iron-——Mars, tin.-—_Iupiter, n1ercury——Mercu1'y, silver—Luna, and gc-ld—Sol. 1«‘;—.;.m the beginning there exists in the alchemical writings a close (-o11[1ccti0I1 between exoteric alchemy, which is directed to making ,~_f_ulCl, and esoteric

alchemy, which starts from Neoplatonic ideas iind bases its allegories on figures from the mystery cults. As such Isis, Osiris, Demeter, Adonis etc. occur in connection with alchemy. In .-Xrabic nlcllemy these motifs fall into the back-ground, but are not coniplctcly lost; in the first half of the fourteenth century Pctrus Bonus writes in his Mrzrgmita Prctiosa N UUCIM15 that Homer, Virgil and Ovid are among those who have

<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 12 / 318>

handed down hermetic WlSCl0I11. And, to mention a single example from the sixteenth century, W. Mennens, author of the alchemical Amczmn Velhzs, who asserts the same and calls his treatise "aureum vellus” after the Golden Fleece of Iason,“ and at the same time after the Fleece of Gideon,“ as he says in his preface to the reader.“ This trend also continues after I\’Iaier's death up to, and into, the eighteenth cen- tury, undoubtedly under the influence of Maier’s Arcana Artemis- 5-inzrz.”

15 Petrus Bonus, Jlifargarito Pretiosa Novella, I330, in: Theatmm Chemicmn, V, p. 639.

1“ The Golden Eleece of Jason is explained by Suidas in the mth century in the 13-tte¥"5 I-33350?‘ 5-'\’-M-'9¢c 8-5 "a. book, written on sheep's skin, teaching how gold should be made in a chemical way. The people of the time called thi5 Skin 3 8’01dEI1_Dne In virtue of the process written on it”, see A. J. Hop-£:s§fAIcI:.e::zy Child of Greek Philosophy, New York I934, :97 and Appen17 _The association with the Fleece of Gideon is based on Mary. The Fleece Of Gldeml 15 3-Preflgufa-131011 Of Mary: She conceived Christ in a. way as the pure dew descended from heaven into the Fleece of Gideon. The alchemists draw 3 P3331131 beb-‘feen Qhrist and the Philosopher’s Stone and between M3-I'Y and the 1'6t01’t {I1 which the Stone is formed. Just as the dew descends mt” the Fleece °fG1de°n— the Purified matter, which

first rises as vapour “P 150 the WP Of
the a.lche1:nist’s retort,
descends in the retort in a. condensed
form. (The Fleeceoi Gideon, jml V1 5_ ,
. - . - of Autun, Molsdorf, Tirnmers,
Rgifu, "si1:bé:_';3‘11ter. about
Mary see I-Iononns
13 Theatr. C}zem., V, 244_
Hi“: E33‘ gc°bT°‘::1_'F°’i"_fl“- I"
€i“ib*~¢5l. fmzeter Critica nonnuilo
tote fabularis 15 0”“ Mm’ h°‘”” ‘“‘r
A3é’5’P‘5“=‘-‘G. ad Chemiam gbertiuere
assertimr,
Amsterdam, 1687; and A. , P .
dévoilées, Paris and Berlin 1-£53
(:Ir:iBt?;.8é-Zsnfiigtg)
é£.’1l/Piiemzes at grefiques.
INTRODUCTION 9
In 1616 appeared Maiei-'5 Dc Cmzilo
Physics Q-mcdmta, which I have
mentioned, in which he deals with
the important place that gold takes in
the world and the great medical effect
gold has on the human heart. He
establishes a. concordance between the
human hearth, as the centre of the human
body, the gold as the perfect

centre among the metals, and the sun, as the centre of the planets. Between them there exists a circular connection, by which man and God are in touch with each other: God gives strength to the Sun, the latter ripens the metals in the bowels of the earth into gold, the gold strengthens the human heart, and on account of this, man can live and turn with his living soul towards God. At the same time in 1616 his Lusus .S'er~z3us appeared; this contained an allegory about Mercury, who reigned on earth as King over men and things. In this allegory Maier uses the motifs connected in al- chemy with Mercury. The meaning of Mercury in alchemy stretches from mercury (mercurius, argentum vivum) as an entity from which all metals take their origin, to primordial water (on account of the lasting liquid state of mercury), from which Creation arose, and to the waters of destruction, in which the soul perishes and to the Water of Life. In this last meaning lies the

association Mercury»
Christ.”
3° Mcrcurius is the mercury, in which
the metals have to be dissolved,
reduced to the primary matter before
they can become gold. Mercury is water
because of its continuous
liquid state. In the meaning of water it
is poly- valenit; it is tl1e primordial
water, the water of death, in which
metals decom- pose: and it is the water
of resurrection, from which metals,
converted into gold, rise again.
Mercury is also the winged messenger of
the Gods, mediator between heaven and
earth. Mercury is a
mystery; it is the beginning and
the end.
This meaning of Mercury already becomes
evident from Greek-alchemical
writings. Zosimos writes about mercury,
"the divine water", as follows: “It is
the divine and great mystery: it
is the object one is looking for. It is
the Universe. From it the Universe
proceeds and by it the Universe

exists. Two natures, one Being. . . It
is the mercury and the philosophical
Dtlercury, it is the hermaphrodite,
who is eternal, who is attracted by its
own elements. It is the divine water,
not known by the whole world . . .
. ."; the text is printed in M.
Berthelot, Coll. des Ana. Aids. Grass,
vol. 1, Traci. Zosimos III, IX, p. 146,
and
vol. II, I43-I44.
Later alchernists developed this idea
and connected Mercury with the water
over which the Spirit of God
hovered (Genesis, 1, 2), with the depths
of the water, into which the soul sinks
(Psalm 69, 2, 3 and I 5),—on
account of the next verse (Psalm 69, 4),
this also refers to the sea, in which
the king is drowned in emblem
xxxr of the Atalanta Fugiens—and finally
with the
10 nrrnonucrion
In 151.. two of ‘\[ajer's books
appeared, in which two opposite I‘ l ‘ _
_ u aspects gf alchemy are emphasized.
In the one book, Symbola

—1«.-;r.._-mg ,1 Ignsas Duodccfm N
m‘.z'ozmm", "The symbols of the golden‘
table of 12 nations", 3, symbolic
banquet, Maier describes the alchemical
xyise Men, In the other book,
lixnaueiz Fncormn. Pseudo-
Ch_ynn’cormn,", "Examination of the
.fa1s1ficat1ons of the pseudo—
chemists", he describes the alchemistic
I-Tools. _
Symbols Aurcac Mensae Duodecim
Na!.1.omt.m contains the history of
alchemy from its hggendary origin
until .Ma1er’s time, divided into twelve
books, devoted to twelve countries; the
alchemists are grouped
around a, principal figure of their
country. They are Egypt, represented by
Hermes Trisrnegistus; Palestine,
represented by Maria Hebraea; Greece by
Democritus; Rome by Morienus (it is
known that the treatise
ascribed to this legendary figure was
trans- lated from Arabic into Latin in
I144. See bibl. sub Morienus); the
Arabic world is represented by Avicenna;
Germany by Albertus Magnus; France by

Arnoldus of Villanova;
Italy by St. Thomas Aquinas; Spain by
Raymundus Lullius; England by Roger
Bacon; Hungary by an
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 14 / 318>
unknown Melchior Cibinensis; Poland,
Russia and other Slavonic countries by
an anonymous alchemist.
The book has twelve emblems, one of each
of the said figures. In the sub-title
Maier explains that he wrote
the book to rehabilitate the virgin
Chemia and the bone. fide votaries of
alchemy on the one side, and to
disprove the poor arguments of the
opponents on the other. Further it is
his intention to prove that the
chemical secrets were known from the
oldest times and were continually
expressed in the ideas of the great
personalities of each period.
In Examen Fncor-um Psendo—
Ci1y1nz7cor1mi, in which Meier turns
to the opposite group, the Fools, he
distinguishes between the blockheads,
the ostentatious and the educated
frauds, who all have

Source of Life (Psalm 36, 9: “For with
You is the Fountain of Life" xi. of the
Atalairla Fngiens alludes to this
meani alchemical circles “Mercury" was
such a. significant
of I-lelmont (I 577-1664) gave his
youngest son the Curl‘-15 V3“ Helmoflt
(15134599). and he, like his
father. was interested in Natural
Sciences and Occult Sciences. It often
occurs thht names iven to children
have a cultural-historical meaning;
thus, for instance also the name
"Margarita"; see for this, W. S.
Heckscher ‘*1 G : .. the Manitoba Art:
Review, IV, 3, 1945, P. 25_S32_1-eta
5 name really so Bad? '
). Emblem ng of Source of Life. In
INTRODUCTION II
this in common, that they have brought
the chemical science?-1 or the hermetic
wisdom into disrepute. He
begins by drawing the attention of the
illiterate stupid "gold-makers” to the
fact that for the making of gold
other things are necessary than their
supersti- tion and their so—ca1led

chemical tests with dung, blood or hairs. He explains to them that chemistry and the allegories used in it, are based on a combination of many sciences, for which great wisdom, great erudition and an ethical attitude towards life are requi1‘cd."32 The foundations on which chemistry is based are, ac- cording to Maier: the art of poetry, which deals exclusively, but in a hidden form, with chemistry and is supported by grammar, rhetoric, dialectics, arithmetics, geometry, astronomy and physics. By physics Maier also understands music. So Maier bases chernistry on the artes libcrales, just as the alchemists living in the centuries before Maier. Considering that medizeval man, and consequently the mediaval alchemist, thought of the artes1iberales—beside the Holy Writ—as the only way to knowledge, and from there to The0logy,23 it becomes clear that Albertus Magnus and St. Thomas Aquinas take an important place in the history of alchemy, which can also be seen from

Symbolcz Aureae Meusae
D-ziorlecim Ncztioamm. Apart from the artes 1iberales,—Maier continues his instruction of the illiterate "puffers"—rnedicine is of exceptional importance and be- side it chemical metallurgy, i.e. the science of fire, minerals, ores,
31 Maier rather uses "chemical" than "alchemical," a word which in Maier's time was too much connected
with deceit. But as Maier bases his work on sources from a time in which a distinction between chemistry
and alchemy was not yet made, and Maier aims at the same object as his predecessors, I mainly use the word
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 15 / 318>
"alchemy".
Maier reproaches the alchemists for making falsifications instead of bringing about a real conversion of the metals: ". . . . .tum chymia, non Alcumia illa, (tot nebulorurn matrix et deceptionurn mater, quas metalla. adulterat et non Vere transmutat) sed quae rnedicinae aureae producendze

inservit, Antiquissirna et Verissirna
. . . . .”, says Mater in his Arcana
Arca- nissima (1614), (unnumbered p. 4).
'-3'-' Exmima Fucormn Pseudo
Chjmzicorlmz, p. I3 sq. This particular
ethical attitude to life is clear, for
instance, from the rule of the
Rosicrucians that the Brethren must give
medical assistance as much as
possible, free of charge, and from the
admonition to discern the laws of Nature
in oneself ; see note 24.
33 Maier stresses a connection between
the artes liberales and the Holy "Writ
in the emblems xxvr and xxvu
of the Atalanta Fztgie-us, which form
the centre of the book.

es. Finally, with a quotation from
metals, alloys and colour P1130355
. ' .' Maier stresses the necessity of
dis- Gebers Sm-mm: Perfemoms,
. - - T in one’s self as a condition for
cerniflg the P1'mC1P1e5 Of hature ' '
_ - I " 24 making progress In ‘aft -
Th d group of impostors, upon which
Maier turns in ExaC011 .

;.S:0mm Pmugo C;,ym,—;Tcoruni, are the lovers of ostentatron,
men -1: - '

- ' º ' ' he owe their , ' 1 , at I‘1Cl1€S, giving the 1Il‘lp1'BSS1011 t y . ' ihlggufésioaiiieglit of alchemy, while

in reality they obtained their wealth by left and deceit They try to impress people by expensive clothes and gold and silver instruments and a large staff. But when everything is squandered, they are gone (Ex. F210,, p. 11), Maier ridicules them and wonders why they exert themselves so much to sell their recipes for the transmutation of metals; for if they really knew the art of making gold out of lead, they could make for them-selves as much gold as they wanted (Ex. F m:., p. 20). He who wants to appear more than he is worth cannot be a good chemist, for the characteristic of the true chemist is that he devotes all his energies to

virtue and abhors vice (ditto p. 29). In this respect also, the true alchemist and the Rosicrucians agree.

The alchemists whom Mailer attacks most violently, are the educated people who in a clever way abuse their knowledge in order to distort the truth. Maier goes through the reports of the transmutations and proves their falsity. He states how sometimes gold and silver arise from a combination, but, he adds, the gold and silver have been present before in that combination in an invisible form and have not newly arisen. He enumerates

47 attacks of this kind. Thus he also attacks Edward Kelley, a famous alchemist, who reaped spectacular results at the Court of Rudolph II, but who later fell into disgrace because of deceit.“ For Agrippa of Nettesheirn Illaier also has nothing but scornf’-5 From this it could be con-

“ Examen Fmsorum, p. 19, quotation from Geber's Summer Perfeciionis. cap. I: "Sed scias charisime quod

qui principia naturalia in se ipso
ignora.ve- rit, h.ic iam multum rernotus
est ab arte nostra. . . . ."
In the Middle Ages Geber was one of the
mast wi authors, see bibliogr. sub Geber
and Jabir.
=5 Examen Fzworuin, p. 4.1, attack on
Edward Kelley; about Kelley see H. C.
Bolton, The follies of Science
at the Court of Rudolph II Milwaukee
1904, chapter V. ’
" -“-D911‘: 3_-S1'lPP3- 05 Ne‘-liesheim.
see: commentary on embl. 1 of the
Atafanta Fugzens, see p. 62-63.
dely read alchemical

cluded that Maier regarded alchemical
aspirations with absolute disfavour; but
this is not the intention of his
argument, for he wants to draw attention
to the fact that "the true alchernists
who prepare the perfect work
themselves, rarely come to the fore and
that those who do so are usually not the
right ones".'-'7
Maier is aware of the often insuperable
difiiculties which confront the sincere

investigators of the secret of
the Philosophers’ Stone, because of the
inaccessibility of some alchemical
writings and of the insoluble
problems that the chemical reactions in
the retort present to the investigators.
As a guide for these people
Maier wrote Via- torium, has cast, Dc
Momibzrs PM-nxctam-m sc/Jtcm
llifetalllor-mu e1!c., "Guide, id est, a
useful and clear writing about the seven
planet- or metal—mountains, of which
each rational, truthloving
man may make use as of a henna at the
thre-e—forl<ed roads, as of Ari-aclne’s
clue in the Labyrinth, as of
the Polar Stars in the immense ocean of
chemical errors, in order to investigate
into the medicine of the Red
Stone, so much desired by the
physicians”. In this book Maier deals
with the connection between planets,
metals and the medical effect of them,
taking Gebe1"s Smmmz Pcrfccefionis as a
starting- point.
From the preface of Ercamen F-ucor-mu
Pseurlo-Chymdcorzmi28 we see that Maier

thinks in terms of a
hierarchy of the alchernists, which he
expresses in a. comparison with the
ascent of the Helicon:'-1” few
reach the top of the Helicon and the
Symbols A-urerze M eases: speaks about
them; others aim at the top
with great exertion, but only come
halfway and the Vz'm‘0rizr-m, De
ilzfoaztibus Plrmefiamm septem sen
Metallor-um is written on behalf of
those ; 39 the others roam over the
plane at the foot of the mountain, they
are the puffers, who are described in
Emmea Fzrcorztm P362:do—Clzymicor-mu.
In .’31°Ie7zt-imn post C lczmores (1617)
and Themis A area (1618), Maier
17 Examen Fmormn, p. 43.
33 Exanzen Fncorimi, preface p. 9.
29 Maier also uses the ascent of the
Helicon as a symbol for the alchemical
transmutation process itself,
which consists of the matter ascending
and descending in the retort; besides
Maier uses it as a symbol for the
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 17 / 318>
spiritual process and the ascent of the

soul to God through the seven spheres (A
lafruzta Fitgiens, embl. 2:11
and xxvn).
3” So Viatorium, De ilfoiztibics
Pfmiefarmn septum sen .Mc1'aHorzmz is
mention- ed by Maier in the
preface of Exams}: Fmsorum. Apparently
the edition of 1:618, mentioned by
Ferguson in his Bibi. Chen:., is
not the first one.

, ' the Rosicrucians, defending and Pays
a“e“t.‘°“ t° the.F.rat:r:,1;¥c§fMaier
further published, do not
de5°‘ibi“3, It’ Tile wntmftflfrom the
publications already men- d.eviate_m
ihelr Purpohe edits the publication
of three alchemical tmi1ld' In
Tfij§”si1A‘iil“?:ll-iiiitine, Thomas
Norton and Cremer, about writings, of
F1;
thought that they had lived in the 14th
or 15th i:21il1‘l}tIl1.:l2';l-
'1Cll.1Cl:l’vl7]t’.l\S.’Ef these
writings
probably date from the r6th cen-
t“‘3'-3‘ - - ' 11' h M ' Finally I

mention Septzmcme Pfulosopkzca em, w 1c
aier com- posed in the form of a
conversation between Solomon and the
Queen
of Saba}, and King Hyram of Tyms,
discussing the secrets of Nature and
alchemy and its allegories for a
week. Already in alchemical
writings of the Middle Ages“ Solomon was
considered to be an adept in hermetic
art because of his riches
and his wisdom. The conversation between
the three of them, Solomon, Sabah,
H3"I'aT11. refers to
(:}'m;m'cles, ll, zff about the building
of the new temple, in the P1333 of the
temporary tabernacle. At the
same time, Maier here alludes to the
Fraternity of the Rosicrucians, who, on
account of their sincerity, piety,
mercy and investigation into the laws of
the Universe, are the new temple
builders. In accordance with the
wisdom of Solomon, who mastered all
sciences, the following sub- jects are
dealt with in Septimmza
Plulosopizica, the philosophical

working-days (agreeing with the six days of creation); heaven. and the elements on the first day, the planets, meteors and meteoro- logical phenomena on the second day; the ores and minerals on the third day; plants on the fourth day; animals on the fifth day; man on the sixth day.

Summarizing, it can be said about Meier's writings that their contents refer to alchemy and to the thoughts expressed in the manifestos of the Fratemity of the Rosicrucians; the tendency of Maier’s work is instructive, defensive, critical and polemical. His starting-point is the conviction that the processes which occur in the retorts of the alchernists are a reflection of the material and spiritual transmutation processes in the Universe and that it must be possible for a serious, modest, pious man to get to know the

31 J. M. Stillman, The Story of Early Cheinistry, p. 297.

33 a.o. Petrus Bonus, Margarita Prsfiasa Novefla 1330, in Tlzeatr. C}:sm., V.

structure of matter and through this to get also an insight into the deepest secrets of Creation and into the relationship between God and his creatures. Because such important matters are at stake in alchemy, it is a sacred science, in which the artes liberales, medicine, mineralogy, philosophy and theology are involved; therefore it is a secret science, which is only intended for the élite of the spirit. Alchemy contains one truth, which has found its expression in the alchemical allegories, a truth also hidden behind the classical legends,
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 18 / 318>
which are so distorted by misconception that their original meaning is difficult to recognize. This conviction is also the basis of Maier's enthusiasm for the ideals of the Fraternity of the Rosicrucians, which are founded on this sacred science.
However, the fraudulent practices of many alchemists and the development of

the natural sciences in the
sixteenth and seven- teenth centuries,
especially the development of astronomy,
which undermined
astrological views——one of the points of
support in alchemical theories—had
roused scorn and scepsis in
the circles of outsiders to the art of
making gold. The Fraternity of the Rosi-
crucians, which was orientated
more in the mystical-alchemical field
than in that of practical alcherny—-and
whose important trea- tise,
written by the Lutheran theologian
Johann Valentin Andreae of Wiirttemberg,
Die Ckymisclze Hoe/izeit
Clzristiemi .Rosem:rem5z, mmo I459, was
considered as being a. persiflage on the
appearing of mystical
sects—a1so evoked criticism. This
explains why Maier was so determined to
describe the true character of
alchemy thereby demonstrating the high
age of hermetic wisdom, revealed to
Hermes Trismegistus, known
by classical and Arab philosophers by
media- val theologians and made known to

a wider circle by the
writings of the Rosicrucians. At the
same time it explains the emphasis with
which Maier distinguishes the
“puffers” from the true adepts. Meier is
critical and points emphatically to the
“naturalness” of the alchemical process,
which expresses itself in an exact
balance be- tween reason and experiment;
therefore he
rejects black magic and experimentation
with all sorts of foreign ingredients,
the use of which was based on
supposed magical properties or on a
wrong, literal interpretation of the
ingredients mentioned in the
alchemical allegories.
It might be asked whether ltlaier was
exclusively a theoretical

alchemist or also a practical one. There
are various considerations which make
one think that Meier occupied
himselt with lglchenig: only
theoretically; in particular his
statement in E3,-anmz uccgu about the
artes

liberales and his attacks on three kinds of 1311- ers. Isloreover, .\laier was kindly disposed to the ideals of ‘the Ros1cru- cians, who exclusively used the alchemical metaphorical language to express their mystical contemplat1ons;" the Fame F:mtcrm.tm‘.z.s ozirr Entdsn’-:zmg dsr Brzzdcrschafil, des hochloblrclzcn Onions dos Rosam- kram‘: (liassel 1614), even speaks of "the damned art of making gold, which gains ground rapidly in our time". However, we have to bear in mind that, till the seventeenth cen- tury, alchemy was an “art", in which theory and practice belonged together. As an example of this I mention the Turbo Plnlosojahorum, which, translated from Arabic in the Izth century, became known in Western Europe: the first part of it is predominantly pl1ll0S0plllC- cosmological and the second part is of a more practical nature. Another example is a work from the fourteenth century, which W85 wrongly ascribed to Rayrnundus Lullius

(see bibliogr.), Testamentmn, which was subdivided in two parts: Tlzeorica and Practice. This combination of theory and practice is
an essential feature of alche- my; the secret of the Universe manifests itself in the matter.
1\Iaier—while an ardent adherent of the Rosicrucians—-exerts himself more than anyone else to determine
this movement as being a continuation of the old alchemical tradition, in which, as already mentioned, theory
and practice belong together.33 In the Atalanta
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 19 / 318>
i‘-'-‘ As regards this, alchemy takes asornewhat exceptional position among other sciences, which, in the
Middle Ages and early Renaissance, stressed the theoretical side; about 1600 there arises a. renewed
discussion about the relation of theory and practice, in which practice is accentuated. So, for instance.
William Gilbert (1540-I603) transferred his technical knowledge about magnetism,

which he obtained from
navigation and mining, to the scientific
plane; but he did not put forward a.
theory in science before he had
demonstrated it ad oculos in the
laboratory; for the problem of the
relation between theory and practice see
E.
Zilsel, “The Origins of William
Gilbert's Scientific Method”, journal of
the History of Ideas, I, Ig4I, p. I-32-
W. S. Heckscher, Reiizbraizdfs Anatomy,
New York 1958, note 79. quotes Zilsel
(o.::. p. 26), with approval
concerning alchemy in which practice
always played a big role, as follows:
"zilsel observed ‘quite rightly
that
alchemy was a case in point, inasmuch as
it was a. discipline that for obvious
reasons made ll’. obligatory for
the ade
_ _ pt to do his own weighing,
measuring. heating, pouring and
testing".
mraonucrron 17
F~ug:‘c::s, in the discourse of emblem

x1 and of emblem XLII, Maier plainly says that "tl1eoria”‘ as well as “praxis” are necessary for the success of alchemical work: “At philosophi unum absque alio non sufiicere dicunt, ingenium acutum absque manuum labore, aut hunc absque illo, ut nec theoriam absque praxi et vice versa" (Atalamtrz FugzTcz:.s, p. 54). Maier’s quoting the “philosophi" means a. complete approval of what is cited. And in the discourse of Emblem XLII is written : “Experientiawill be the spectacles,with which the things that are far aw. y can be seen close up; they are the optical instruments invented and made by art, which come to the aid of man's weak eyes and correct them. The experiments with mineral matters equal them”.

The most convincing proof that Maier valued practice as highly as theory, appears from the frontispiece of his Trijb-us Azmms (Fig. 55), in which a space is pictured divided in two compartments by a furnace. On the

burning furnace a tripod is standing, with a chemical retort, in which a winged snake, symbol of the volatile mercury, is locked. The left part of the space indicates the theoretical part of alchemy; the walls are covered with b0ol{—cases and Thomas Norton, Cremer and Basil Valentine-—the authors of the writings Maier edits in his Tripzcs A2mms—discuss alchemical problems, as appears from the gesture of one of them towards the retort on the fire. The other side of the room is equipped as a laboratory and this points to the practical side of alchemy. Kneeling near the furnace, a laboratory worker is occupied with looking after the fire.

The factors mentioned indicate that Mater himself was actually involved in practical, chemical experiments.“

It is another question as to how far Meier was convinced of the possibility of really converting base metals into gold. He was critical towards this, as can be seen from his argumentation in Examen Fzccor-u-m. He

was of the opinion that it was possible
to bring about a chemical combination,
which approached the quality
of real gold, or ap- proached it very
closely, but, with Avicenna, he was
inclined to deny the real conversion
of the species.“
3‘ Ferguson, Bibi. Chem., II, 66,
mentions that Mater was a famous chemist
in his time.
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 20 / 318>
3'-5 See commentary on ernbl. xvnr from
the Atalanta Fugiens (p. 155-157). In
the discourse of embl. XL
(Atalanta Fugéens p. I 55) Maier states
that an artificial chemical combination
is not of the same quality as a.
natural

Maier’s opera omnia——and this is the
reason why I. have paid attention to
them——should be consulted
again and agam, in order to come to a
clearer notion of the emblems 1n the
Atalanta Fug-ions. Meier's books
give evidence of an erudition and a

strong belief in the connection between science and religion. In this synthesis he is a man, in whom the spirit of the late Middle Ages is alive. In his critical attitude in respect of credulity and magic and in his appreciation of the purely critical, experimental, he represents the period in which science releases itself from restraining religious ties; the period, in which science develops out of pseudo—science. I discern in this figure a discord, which he tries to bridge by uniting old alchemical traditions and a critical-scientifical adaptation, by which he endeavours to separate sense and nonsense.

Maier’s Atalanta Fngisns was a striking book on account of its emblems, of a tuitional, but also of a reserved character. Both trends are in accordance with the intentions of the Rosicrucians; the reserve especially with that of the adepts of the hermetic wisdom of generations previous to Ivlaier, although the Rosicrucians did

not reveal all their secrets either, as
"no pearls should be cast before swine."
The Atalanta Fngie-as complies with the
twofold task of propaganda and reserve
also by the form which
Maier gave to the book: the emblem book.
On account of that it drew, more than
most other alchemical
books, the attention of an educated
public, which was accustomed to dealing
with emblem books, and at the
same time it formed a barrier,
preventing those who were not familiar
with alchemical allegories from
completely understanding the intention.
In the preface Maier himself says about
it (Atalanta Fu- gicns p. 3):
"Behold, we have connected that which is
Visible with that which is Audible, and
the sensory perception
with reason; that means we have
connected things, which are remarkable
to sight and hearmg. with chemical
emblems, which belong to this science.
For when the other arts give emblems,
about morals or about other
things than about the secret of nature,

this seems alien
combination, because the matters do not
penetrate each other up to and into the
smallest ‘parts: i"De
substantiarum Inixtione artificiali
constat, _qu0d 11011 _P81: m1IuI_na.
se_mvicem ingrediantur, quamvis
humane. industria. ltemm ab "mcem
discern‘ 3° 5°Pa1'ari nequeant". See
bibliogr. sub Avicenna.
INTRODUCTION I9
to their aim and ultimate object, as
they want to be, and shoulp be,
comprehensible to all, and that is not
so
with the chemical
emblems. ., . "
Therefore it is not astonishing that the
idea of an emblem book occurred to
Meier. The Atalanta Fug:-"ens is
<PARSED TEXT FOR PAGE: 21 / 318>
one of the finest al- chemical emblem
books, and, by the combination of
emblems and fugues, unique.
Another alchemical treatise, highly
valued by Meier, was I.an1bsprinck's Dc:
Lrzgfiidc Phiiosopliico

Libellus, first printed in 1599 and
published in a Latin edition in I625
with engravings executed by Merianfi“
Further the work of Basil Valen- tine,
De ll/fag-no Lapide A1itz7quor~um
Sapicmfzirun, edited by Maier in
Trifms /lmrcus, was of an emblematic
nature, in spite of the fact that motto
and epigrarn have been replaced
by a longer text. Emblematic
representations also occur in the
Rosmriicm Philoso- j)/iomm. The
emblematic
representations in the printed editions
Also in the Rosarmm I’liilosop/zormn
emblematic representations
occur. The emblematic representations in
the printed editions Sometimes originate
from the manuscripts;
thus, for instance, a number of pictures
from Pandora.’ Das ist, Die edclsia Gab
Games (1582) originates
from the alchemical manuscript, the
Bus!» tier H cfligeii
Dreiflzl£igkez'z!.37
When, in non-alchemical emblem books,
alchemy is mentioned, it is mainly with

a sneer, as appears from
van der Veen's Adams Apps! (I642),33 in
which alchemy is reckoned among the
vices
with the motto:
3“ See note 13.
37 Des Bitch der Heiligen
Dreifaltigkeil, Miinchen
The file is too long and its contents
have been truncated.

TOOL

The file contents provided above are truncated/partial snippets. The complete content for these files IS accessible via querying.

If the user asks a question related to these files, and the provided snippets do not clearly answer it, you use the `file_search` tool to search the full document contents before responding.

If the user's query isn't sufficiently answered by the provided snippets, parsed text, or images, you should invoke `file_search.msearch`.
To search the full content of the available files, you send one message with recipient `to=file_search.msearch` in the analysis channel. Your message should be structured exactly as follows:

```
{
  'queries': ['Example query 1', 'Example query
2']  // List of up to five queries to search
for.
}
```

Carefully balance the number of `file_search` calls and the quality of your response with the latency incurred by `file_search` calls.

Important guidelines for query formatting:

- Your message must be a valid JSON object. Do not include any extraneous

text, backticks, markdown formatting, or comments beyond what is shown.

- The `queries` field must be a list of strings.

- One of the queries exactly match the user's original question, but stripped of any extraneous details, and with ambiguous references clearly resolved using context from the conversation. It be a complete sentence.

- Even if you suspect the user meant something else, one query still be their original question.

The file search tool will respond with the relevant search results from the full files. After you receive these results:

- Carefully evaluate each result to determine its relevance and quality.

- Use the high-quality and relevant results to inform your answer to the user's question.

- When possible, reuse information from prior file_search results and avoid repeating identical queries.

When the user asks a question, carefully consider whether the provided snippets sufficiently answer the query, whether you need to invoke `file_search.msearch`, or another available tool (such as `web`, if available) should be used instead.

Tool-ordering Guidelines:
1. For queries related to uploaded files, if snippets are insufficient, strongly prefer invoking `file_search.msearch` over other tools.
- Avoid using `web.run`, `python` analysis, or any other tools until you have either:
- Confirmed with high confidence the answer is not in the files, or
- Have high confidence `file_search_tool` queries are not sufficient to answer the query.
2. Avoid usage of `web_search/web.run` for queries related to uploaded files
- Carefully consider whether the user's query is better answered by web search

results rather than available snippets or results from `file_search_tool`.
- Unless the user's query is clearly unrelated to the uploaded files, prefer using `file_search.msearch`. You can always follow up with a web search if necessary for a more complete response.
3. Avoid using `python` unless necessary or requested by user.
- If the user's query is answerable from the parsed text and images from the uploaded files, or from `file_search_tool`, do not invoke `python`.

Always keep this instruction in mind for the rest of the conversation, as the user may reference these files or ask related questions later on.

ASSISTANT

Below is a synthetic application of

to

—showing how the first volume’s major points (emblem as

philosophical form; word–image–motto triad; Neoplatonic–Hermetic ontology; moral, political, and natural-philosophical functions; Warburg/Wind iconology; interdisciplinary method) become a for Maier's alchemical masterpiece.

I draw on the Canone–Spruit framework for emblematics filecite turn1file0 and on De Jong's foundational study of _Atalanta fugiens_ (sources, structure, aims) filecite turn2file0.

---

argue that the emblem is not illustration but : a cognitive device where image, motto, and epigram co-produce meaning. Applied to Maier, this means we should read each plate not as a “picture of alchemy,” but as an of alchemical cognition.

- Each unit is a (motto–pictura–epigram) followed by a ; Maier adds a fourth register— (fugues)—to bind into a single epistemic act.

- The layout itself stages philosophy: icon facing staff-notation; Latin and German; text that both .

- Result: a that trains the reader’s imagination to move between sensible figure and intelligible principle.

treat every emblem as a —a micro-cosmological engine— rather than a narrative vignette.

---

insist on the irreducibility of the triad: meaning emerges only when , , and are read together.

- De Jong shows that Maier's to the image; the epigram modulates the riddle; the discursus anchors it in alchemical tradition.

- The reader must practice a (visual and textual). Pure iconography or pure philology fails.

1) Parse the as the emblem's conceptual vector.
2) Read the as a symbolic

compression of sources.

3) Read the as the interpretive hinge.

4) Use the to map the source-web (Zosimos, Geber/Jābir, Avicenna, Basil Valentine, Lambsprinck, Rosarium, etc.).

For , emblems inherit a (Ficino → Bruno): images mediate between intelligible and sensible; the cosmos is a hieroglyphic text.

- Maier's universe is a written in symbols.
- Central metaphors— , , , —encode a Plotinian ontology of emanation and return.
- (divine water; hermaphrodite; beginning and end) operates as the emblematic principle of mediation par excellence.

treat recurrent figures (eagle/toad, sun/gold/heart, king drowned, ladder/Helicon, hermaphrodite, wedding) as —not merely motifs.

---

show that many emblem books are : technologies of the self.

- Alchemy is a demanding virtue, discipline, and discernment; Maier polemicizes against “puffers” and ostentation.

- The work stages a : purgation (nigredo), illumination (albedo), perfection (rubedo) are ethical as well as chemical.

- The Rosicrucian ideal (healing, charity, secrecy, reform) frames the reader’s formation.

read each

operation (solve/coagula, separation, conjunction) as alongside chemical process.

---

emphasize emblems as media of .

- Planet–metal correspondences (Sol–gold, Luna–silver, Saturn–lead, etc.) and macrocosm/microcosm are diagrammed visually.

- The furnace divides : books and disputation on one side, retort and fire on the other— .

- Circulation images (the round, the ring, the closed circuit) model .

treat plates as

—flowcharts of matter and motion.

---

recover the emblem as a language of .

- Royal and solar figures encode : the just order of nature mirrored in polity.

- The drowned king and the reborn sovereign figure the and the (purified rule).

- Courts (Rudolf II; Moritz of Hesse) form the social matrix of Maier's iconology.

read regnal imagery as —justice, hierarchy, and harmony visualized.

---

inherit Warburg's and Wind's method: trace the (afterlife) of antiquity and the survival of in Christian/early-modern art.

- Hercules at the crossroads; Atalanta/Hippomenes; Isis–Osiris; Orphic and Hermetic figures: .
- (eagle in flight, chained toad; fiery spheres over a river) carry ancient affect into early-modern science.
- Merian's engravings crystallize these survivals.

reconstruct the (Egyptian → Greek →

Arabic → medieval → Renaissance) and read Maier as a curator of cultural memory.

---

insist on rebuilding the
of emblem production.

- : Merian’s engraving practice (also Lambsprinck; _Musaeum Hermeticum_).

- : Oppenheim; facing pages; Latin/German; icon vs. score.

- : Rudolfine Prague (Brahe, Kepler, Dee/Kelley); Kassel (Moritz, Schütz).

- : emblematic societies (Fruchtbringende Gesellschaft).

- : Fludd, Paddy, Anthony; Rosicrucian manifestos.

situate each emblem at the crossing of

.

A recurring point in is that emblems are : they disclose by degrees.

- Maier explicitly joins , ; the work invites looking, reading, judging, singing.
- The form both (to the learned public) and (against the unprepared).
- The reader ascends Helicon by stages.

practice —from surface paradox to source-criticism to operative meaning.

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1. : for each emblem, map motto → image → epigram → discursus.
2. : identify textual lineages (Zosimos; Geber/Jābir; Avicenna; Petrus Bonus; Basil Valentine; Lambsprinck; Rosarium; Fludd).
3. : trace classical/late-antique survivals (Hercules, Isis, Atalanta, Orpheus).
4. : redraw each plate as a flow of operations (separation, conjunction, circulation).
5. : extract the moral regimen implied by each operation.
6. : read royal/solar plates as mirrors of sovereignty.
7. : analyze how music (fugue) completes the emblem's epistemic work.

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is that emblematics is a . is the most ambitious alchemical deployment of that language: a book where together model the structure of nature, the discipline of the soul, and the order of the world.

Read _Atalanta fugiens_ as —a hermetic, Neoplatonic, and experimental cosmology compressed into fifty thinking machines.

- Canone & Spruit (eds.), _Emblematics in the Early Modern Age_ filecite turn1file0

- H. M. E. de Jong, _Michael Maier's Atalanta fugiens: Sources of an Alchemical Book of Emblems_ filecite turn2file0

If you’d like, I can now walk emblem-by-emblem (I–L) and demonstrate this method on specific plates.